Volume I: The She-Ra

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Mature

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Glimmer Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer Siblings

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by AzimuthStars

Summary

Nineteen years ago, a city fell to the Horde and the only survivor was a little magicat. Saved by a sorcerer and raised as his daughter, Bright Moon is the only home Catra has ever known. When Micah dies and leaves Catra alone, she becomes determined to end her war and make sure his death wasn't in vain.

Meanwhile, the daughter of a being of an immense magical power and the most powerful sorcerer in Bright Moon was kidnapped. Raised as a fighter for the Horde and told her parents abandoned her, friends-turned-rivals Glimmer and Adora face a constant battle against eachother as they battle for dominance in the eye of their adoptive mother, Shadow Weaver.

Notes

Warnings for this fic:

Depression
Violence
Emotional abuse
Some scary scenes

If there are chapters with ones that fall outside this an extra note will be added!

See the end of the work for more notes

Prologue

Somewhere, in the distance, a child cries out for her mother.

A mother long dead by now, in the thick of smoke and ash as the city of Half-Moon burns to the ground.

That doesn’t deter Bright Moon's finest sorcerer from immediately moving at the sound of the child. He runs, through charred remains of buildings and bodies, boots crunching on glass and wood as his hands find the edges of a collapsed home.

"Don't just stand there! Help me with this!" The sorcerer cries out, gesturing at the soldiers following him. The two soldiers approach from either side, lifting away broken bits of wood in every effort to find the crying child.

Then, the sorcerer sees it. A glimpse of the most beautiful pair of gold and azure eyes peeking out from beneath the rubble. The child couldn't be more than a few months old, left alone in this world by a cruel and unforgiving master.

"Someone get me something to wrap her up in!" He yells, beginning to rush back towards their ships. The group had been too late to save Half-Moon. By the time they had arrived it was mostly a pile of bodies and charred buildings.

Something which scared the sorcerer. Only a single person he knew was powerful enough to commit an atrocity on this level. Someone he thought long dead.

"Micah." A cold, cruel voice emerges from the smoke.

Micah's heart stops. It can't be. He destroyed her years ago. "Light Spinner."

Light Spinner chuckles as she steps out from beyond the choking black fog. "That's a name I haven't heard in a long time. Speaking of time, how long has it been now Micah? fifteen years?"

"You're supposed to be dead." Micah growls.

"Ah, yes, maybe I am. But dark magic has its ways, after all." Light Spinner lets out a cold, calculating chuckle.

"Why?!" Micah yells, gesturing around himself. "Why all this?!"

Micah can't see behind Light Spinner's mask, but he knows that she's smiling, eyeing him up and down coldly with a darkly coloured chuckle.

Light Spinner gestures behind herself, to the crew of Horde foot soldiers dragging a large crystal away from the wreckage of a building that could very well have once been a temple.

"A runestone." Micah stifles a gasp. "You came here for a runestone."

"How intuitive of you. I'm so excited to show my old apprentice my new power." Light Spinner lunges, stopped only by Micah countering her with his staff, throwing her off balance and throwing her to the ground.

Micah turns and looks towards the ships, at the general. "Take her and go! I'll catch up."

By now Light Spinner stands behind Micah, shocking him with a bolt of electricity that travels through his bones and into his nerves. He crumbles to the ground, erratically shaking as his muscles react to the constant voltage.

Soon Light Spinner stops, leaving Micah on the ground. His skin is smoldering, burnt badly in some spots to the point of peeling. Micah reaches for his staff, but is too late as the witch reaches down, picking it up with her left hand.

"You won't need this anymore, Micah. Your time is not long for this world. My new apprentice will drive a knife into the heart of

your rebellion. I'm sorry it had to be this way." The witch chuckles evilly. “Then again, maybe I’m not.”

Micah makes an effort to stand, getting about halfway before his leg gives out and he collapses back to the ground. "You monster.Spinner!" He screams.

"That name means nothing to me anymore, my former apprentice." Light Spinner steps around Micah slowly, melting into the shadows on the ground. "Light Spinner is dead, Micah. Tremble before the Shadow Weaver, Force Commander of the Horde and greatest sorceress in existence." She cackles loudly.

Micah groans, collapsing to the ground. His ears ring as blood rushes into his head. Blackness surrounds him quickly, taking hold as violently as the night.

Micah jerks awake, sitting up suddenly enough in his infirmary bed to send sparks of pain up his spine and out into his arms. He lets out a loud groan as one of the medics rushes over to help him sit up. Bright, white light poured in through the infirmary windows, almost jarring for Micah after several days of terrible, painful sleep and nightmares of his old mentor.

“I wouldn’t try to stand up just yet, sir. You’ve got a broken leg and she did a bad number on your peripheral nerves. You need to

rest.” The medic looks him up and down, checking the burns on Micah’s shoulders and wrists.

Micah quells his shaking hands, his anxious mind conjuring up images of his infant daughters and wife. The nightmares truly don't get any better, especially after a battle like that one. He hopes the damages aren't too permanent, but they tell him he might never walk normally again.

He supposes he can live with that. He isn't sure anyone else could love that little girl he saved from the fires the way he does now. He wouldn’t let anyone take her away.

By the third day Micah is stable enough to walk, forced to use a crutch to maintain his balance on his bad leg. He wonders if any amount of healing magic could fix this. Though magic is incredible in its ways, sorcerers just aren't miracle workers. Dark magic is the only thing capable of that kind of work.

But only the damned deal in dark magic.

He’s brought out of his darkly clouded thoughts by the sound of the infirmary door opening to reveal General Juliet. The general quite nervously shuffles inside the infirmary and approaches Micah’s bedside with a salute. “The girl we rescued. She’s crying and we don’t know what to do. It’s been an hour since she was quiet.”

“Bring her to me, Juliet.” Micah nods at the general. As if on cue a soldier comes through carrying the magicat baby and reaches out to hand her over to Micah lying in the infirmary bed. The two soldiers quickly turn and exit the room with a *thud* of the door, leaving Micah alone with the baby.

The baby stops crying near immediately and stares up at Micah. She takes a curious hand and reaches up to grab onto his beard. Micah cries out in momentary surprise and pain before he begins to chuckle as the girl giggles. “A feisty one, aren’t we? You and Glimmer will get along.” He grins at the little magicat, who’s become enthralled with him. She stares up at him with eyes of gold and azure, seemingly piercing beyond Micah’s eyes and into his soul, the two sharing a pain no one else could. Micah sits for several hours, holding the child in his arms and keeping her close when a familiar voice weighs in.

“Does she have a name?” The queen’s posh, proper voice cuts through the silence as she approaches her husband and the magicat baby within Bright Moon’s infirmary.

“I was thinking maybe Catra.” Micah grins, earning a coo from the little girl.

“Catra? Isn’t that too on the nose, my love?” The queen chuckles.

“I don’t think so. See? She likes it. Don’t you Catra?” Micah grins down at the baby before his expression turns somber. “She needs a home. She’s the last of her kind. We should take her, Angella.”

Angella sighs, a hint of uncertainty in her voice. “Aren’t we a little tied up with one?”

“Glimmer would love having a sister.” Micah grins, earning an uncharacteristic groan from his wife. “You know I’m right.”

“I know you are. I just don’t know how we’ll survive the two of them.” Angella smiles softly.

Micah is certain he’s right.

Before Micah's mind registers the crashing sound from down the hall he's up and running as fast as he can as he barrels through a doorway and into the hallway. He forces himself to ignore the shooting pain in his already struggling leg as he sprints down the hallway towards his daughter's room, but before he's able to catch himself his leg finally gives out, sending him flying to the ground.

"Shit." He mutters, not usually one for swearing as he picks himself back up and continues to storm down the hall towards his daughters’ bedrooms.

The sorcerer peeks inside Catra's bedroom, looking up and into the bed hoisted in the air. Nothing of interest seems out of place here, but he was certain that the noise had come from this direction. Was he growing paranoid? Worried that someone would come for her after escaping Half-Moon?

Then he hears another crash, again storming across the hall towards Glimmer’s room.

"Glimmer!" Angella cries out from across the hall.

Micah opens the door in time to see darkness surrounding his infant's crib. He quickly shuffles towards it before being knocked off his feet by incredible force. Screams of pain seem to echo around him as the shadows try to consume him.

But Micah stands up again.

He makes another effort to advance towards the crib, each step seeming to fill his feet with cement as he approaches. Evil laughter surrounds him as he finally looks down into the crib.

Nothing.

"What?" Micah mutters.

"You know, you really were my prized pupil Micah. But this little one of yours is more than either of us could ever be. A worthy successor."

Micah whips around to see the Shadow Weaver standing in the window of Glimmer's room, cradling the infant gently as she stares at the king with those soulless, uncaring eyes.

"You let her go." Micah growls with more venom than he had ever mustered before. The man knew the only time to channel his former master was when he faced her.

"I don't think I will. You can have the magicat for all I care. She means nothing to me. Not like this one." The Weaver chuckles coldly.

It's then that Micah loses his temper.

The sorcerer jumps at her, lunging for anything he can grab onto, before coming up empty-handed and nearly tumbling out the window to the ground below.

Laughs echo around him again as he hangs onto the ledge.

"Farewell, Micah."

The cold air seems to dissipate.

"Micah!" Angella grabs onto Micah’s hand and pulls him up through the window, holding onto him tightly.

"I lost her." Micah mutters frantically. "I- I lost her."

"It isn't your fault, my love." Angella looks at him with sorrowful eyes.

"I- I-" Micah breaks down into tears. "I lost Glimmer. I- I lost Glimmer!"

--- Fifteen Years Later ---

Catra's eyes open one at a time, still drowsy from the long night of sleep she's had. She sits up, stretching her arms and legs individually before hopping down from her bed. Magicats prefer to sleep in high places, so naturally her parents accommodated that for her by going overboard. Some magicats were even nocturnal, but Catra dodged that bullet. She doesn't think her dad would have liked her to be awake all night too much.

Speaking of her father, Micah bursts into the room nearly as soon as she makes an indication that she's up. He gets like this every year on this day. It was her birthday, or rather, the day that Micah

found her beneath the rubble. She'd never known her birthday, so they established that specifically this day would be their celebration.

He still struggles on his leg even after all these years. He’s supposed to walk with a cane but Catra has never seen him walk with one, opting instead to tough it out. She thinks he’s too stubborn for his own good in that regard.

Guess she had to get it from somewhere.

She doesn't care much for festivities anyways. Catra prefers to be grateful for things regardless of what day it is. She’s alive after all. She could have died back then or worse. Maybe that makes her simple. She isn't really sure.

"Kitten!" Micah grabs her in a hug mighty enough to crack ribs if he wanted to.

"Hey Dad. Couldn't wait for me to be fully awake, huh?" Catra chuckles.

"No. You know how your old man is. I'm sentimental!" Micah grins. "Besides, I have a surprise for you."

Catra turns red. "You don't have to, you know, Dad."

"But I want to, kitten!" Micah gestures at the door. "Come on!"

"Alright, alright." Catra chuckles.

The pair step out of Catra's room and into the hallway. Every day is a reminder of the day they lost Catra's sister. She hardly remembers her, but it was very hard for her mom and dad when it happened. They remain ultra protective of Catra even now.

"Hey Catra." A voice peeks around the corner.

"Hey Bow. Whatcha got there?" She raises an eyebrow at the boy tinkering with a gadget.

"Upgrading the tracker-pad designs again. I keep finding new ways to make them more efficient. If you want, I can upgrade yours."

"Nah, I'm fine with it as it is. Serves its purpose pretty well if you ask me." Catra chuckles, elbowing Bow in the arm, causing him to yelp.

"Don't do that, Catra! This is very delicate!" Bow protests.

"I'm sure. One thing you and your toys have in common." Catra lets out an amused, maniacal laugh.

"Catra." Micah warns. "Be nice."

Catra looks down disappointedly. "Sorry Bow."

Bow grins, elbowing Catra right back before Catra grabs him, proceeding to give him a noogie as Micah looks on with an exasperated sigh.

"You two…" He trails off.

Before Catra can respond they've arrived in the armory. This wasn't entirely where she was expecting her father to lead her. What kind of surprise had he planned?

"I think you should learn how to fight. And I mean properly fight." Micah walks over to a table with a wooden box on it.

"Wh-why, Dad?" Catra's tone shifts nervously.

"Because regardless of everything, we're still at war. I won't have you stolen away from me." Micah holds the box open for Catra to see inside.

The box contains a pair of gloves, padded and armored with metal plating. At the tips of each finger was a small, retractable blade, sharp as steel and blackened by the forge.

"Whoa." Catra can't contain her wonder at the sight of the gloves.

"Put them on." Micah grins.

Catra slides the left one over her dominant hand, then the right one. She makes a fist, opening and closing it, unsure how to activate the claws.

"Like this." Micah holds her hand, flexing it in a specific way to activate the razor sharp blades.

"Whoa. Dad, these are amazing! They fit perfectly! How- How did you get them like that?" Catra beams.

"May have stolen the measurements from your suit for Princess Prom last year." Micah winks.

Catra retracts the claws, pulling Micah into a tight hug. "Thanks, Dad."

"Of course. But that's not the only thing. We're gonna teach you how to use them too."

"But why?" Catra tilts her head.

"Because eventually you're gonna be old enough to make your own choices, kitten. When you are ready to go out into the world you're gonna be prepared. I'll be damned if I lose my other daughter to the Horde or some other monster." Micah says somberly.

Catra nods. "So when do we start?"

"First thing tomorrow. Today we celebrate your birthday." Micah grins.

"Don't forget your present from me too." Bow chuckles, holding out a tracker-pad.

"Aw, geez, Bow! You didn't have to!" Catra looks away.

"You're my friend. Of course I did." Bow grins.

"What's that? We're *friends* ?" Catra teases.

"Yes, we are." The boy says firmly.

"Well ok then. Guess I have to, *friend.* " Catra grins sharply.

"You're never gonna let me live this down, will you?" Bow says flatly.

"Nope!"

The next day, Micah takes Catra to the training courtyard, where he's had some dummies lined up for the day. Catra still isn't quite sure how the gloves work; she can't quite get them to extend when she wants them to. They almost seem to have a mind of their own. The night before, she put them on to try to see if she could make them cooperate, but instead ended up with quite a few shredded pillows.

"You have to flex your hand backwards to unsheathe them!" Micah calls from the sidelines.

Catra tries it and to her surprise the claws snap forward with a loud *snap* , sharp as steel and ready to go. Catra looks down at them for a moment, really pondering what she was about to do.

Was she really a fighter? Was she cut out for this kind of thing? She looks up at the dummies and eyes each of them closely before her mind settles into resolve.

"AH!" She yells, rushing at one before toppling it over and slashing at it aggressively.

"Catra!" Micah calls. "CATRA!"

Catra stops and looks down at the remains of the dummy before she looks up at Micah with a grin.

"You have to be more elegant than that, kitten." Micah laughs. "Fighting isn't just about landing your attacks. It's a dance between yourself and your opponent for the upper hand."

Micah steps over and widens his stance.

"Come at me." He says as he raises his fists.

Catra's expression changes to one of surprise, she looks down at the gloves soberly and retracts the claws. "No. Dad. I don't want to hurt you."

"Come on kitten. It'll be fine. I'm a big boy." Micah chuckles, gesturing for her to come at him.

Catra eyes him, a little fearful, before her eyes fill with determination. She lunges at Micah, who steps aside, picking her up and throwing her over his shoulder.

"Ow." Catra groans.

"See? You have to anticipate your enemies moves as well as your own." Micah says with a grin.

Catra nods, jumping at him again. This time when Micah tries to grab her she parries and knocks his hand away. Her opposite hand collides with his chest with a *thump* as Micah is knocked clean off his feet.

"Dad! Oh gods. I'm so sorry." Catra covers her mouth.

Micah's laughter starts as a low chuckle before he explodes into a full blown chortle. "That was amazing, kitten! You're a natural."

Catra helps Micah, still full of laughter, to his feet. "You think so?"

"Yeah! No one has ever quite deflected me like that before. You've got it!" He grins.

"King Micah!" General Juliet runs onto the training grounds. "There’s been sightings of the Horde amassing troops near the Whispering Woods."

"This is nothing new, General. The Woods will stop them." Micah nods.

"Sir," Juliet gulps. "One of them is a magic-user."

Micah goes stone cold, beginning to walk with Juliet.

"Wait. Dad! What about our training?" Catra calls.

"That's enough for one day, kitten. We'll get back to it tomorrow." Micah throws her a thumbs up.

The sorcerer spits blood on the ground, looking up at the face of his former mentor. His arms are chained to the walls tightly, allowing no give as he stares at the woman's dark, soulless mask.

"You made quite a stir didn't you Micah?" Shadow Weaver chuckles. "There's nothing for you here. Your rebellion is dying."

"WHERE IS MY DAUGHTER?!" Micah screams before coughing and spitting more blood on the prison floor.

"I have no need for the magicat, Micah. You know this."

"You know what I'm talking about. Quit playing games!" Micah growls.

"Oh? You mean-" Weaver pauses sadistically. "Glimmer?"

The sound of his daughter's name sends Micah into a rage as he struggles against his restraints. Suddenly Micah does the unexpected, breaking the metal restraint around his left wrist and grabbing Shadow Weaver by the throat.

"Where is she!?" He screams as Horde grunts pull his arm away from the witch.

"You'll die before I tell you. Send him to Beast Island." Shadow Weaver coughs and rubs her throat as the soldiers flank Micah, pulling him from the restraints.

"Wait. WAIT!" Micah tries to resist, but the soldiers quickly overpower him. They knock him to the ground and begin to beat him with their batons.

Before long consciousness finally escapes him.

"What do you mean?" Catra's voice cracks as she meets General Juliet's eyes. The dim light of the war room surrounds them in the early hours of the morning.

"We-" Juliet coughs and looks down at her feet. "He's gone, Catra."

Catra recoils in disbelief. "You-You're lying. You're lying! Quit lying to me!" She starts to yell, continuing to back away from Juliet.

"Catra, I know this is hard to hear, but-"

"Shut up! Any moment my dad is gonna walk through that door, right? It's all a big lie!" Tears roll down Catra's cheeks. "Right?"

Juliet collapses into one of the chairs seated at the war room table and places her face in her palms. Catra is shocked to hear her begin to sob as well.

"He's not coming back." Juliet says, strained.

Catra's knees finally give away and she collapses to the floor in panic. The air around her has become like carbon dioxide, impossible to breathe. She thinks she must be dying as her breathing quickens and her tears flood out like water from a broken dam.

Her panic is broken briefly by the door opening with a loud *creak.* Angella shuffles in and looks up in surprise at the sight of the two. It isn't long before Catra runs to her mother and hugs her tight without letting go.

Angella looks down at Catra sadly, pulling her closer into the tight hug.

The Sword

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Bow venture inside the Whispering Woods hoping to find First One's tech worthy of bringing back to Bright Moon. What they find instead turns out to be much more than just tech.

Chapter Notes

> The usual content warnings apply here. This chapter follows the plot of "The Sword" pretty closely and will be the only chapter to do so as far as the series goes. The divergence starts almost immediately after this.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra lays face down in her bed and hopes that the world around her will just quit existing for a moment so she can have a few minutes of peace from the tiring effort of being alive. The few hours she's been confined to her room have begun to wear her down. She hates not getting work done. She hates being alone with her thoughts. She hates-

Something whizzes over her head.

She lifts her head up and looks around until she sees it: an arrow with a note attached embedded in the wall above her bed. Bow, of course. She steps over cautiously and pulls the somewhat crumpled note free.

Look outside. The note reads in relatively neat handwriting.

Catra raises an eyebrow and walks slowly over to her bedroom window opposite the bed. When she arrives she's greeted by the sight of Bow grinning up at her and waving.

"Hey." Bow says.

Catra leans up against the balcony with a small smirk. "Hey. What's up?"

"Nothing. Wanna go look for stuff in the woods?" Bow uses his thumb to point behind him. "I detected a pretty powerful piece of tech not too long ago."

Catra immediately jumps down and tries to land as quietly as she can before standing up with a grin. "I thought you'd never ask. Look at you, Mr. Goodie Two-Shoes Bow!"

"Oh, come on, not all the time." Bow chuckles. "Let’s get going."

The pair wander into the woods, not entirely sure of the direction they're about to take in the dense, overgrown thicket. Catra knows Bow is a good navigator, but the Woods have always sort of freaked her out. She doesn't want to become eternally lost in them, especially when so much is at stake for Bright Moon. The last time she came out here with anyone she was stranded for

days on end and the very notion that it could happen again frightens her to her core.

The pair spend some time wandering through the trees, not sure of what exactly they're looking for quite yet. Catra knows she's seen something here before, like a big building or something. If it's here it's bound to hold something of use to the rebellion. Maybe it has some weapons or plans inside it that could help them against the Horde.

"Come on. We have to be close. The signal's like, right on top of us." Bow grumbles. "Look for anything out of the ordinary. It could be right under our noses."

Catra looks up and sees a bright white glow coming from far deeper in the woods. The light was almost blinding in luminosity, which Catra finds a bit hard to miss. She chuckles and points over to the bright light. "Like that?"

"Oh. Yea. That'll do it." Bow grins.

"Come on. We don’t have all night."

The light gets brighter as the pair wander through the woods. It seems to dance around and shift locations as Catra's eyes dart from tree to tree, searching for the brightly glowing object.

Was Bow's pad wrong?

"I thought you said it was this way?" Catra grumbles.

"The light came from the edge of the forest-" Bow's sentence is cut off by another loud groan from Catra. "The tracker-pad says otherwise."

"You saw it Bow. It came from this way. Why are you trusting that thing over your eyes?!" Catra continues to angrily ramble for a moment as they walk into a clearing. "How do you think we can trust a stupid piece of technology when-"

"Catra." Bow starts. "CATRA!"

Catra stops, looking at Bow with a grumble. "What?!"

Bow points beyond her. "Horde soldier!"

Catra whips around and sees a tall blonde running towards the glowing light. She yells and takes off in a sprint towards the bright light as Bow draws an arrow. Catra barrels over roots and fallen trees towards the glowing object, activating her claws and barely beating the blonde to it. Upon further inspection the object appears to be a large sword, too big for Catra's hands even. She doesn't have time to worry about it, she decides. She has to get

the piece of weaponry away from the Horde soldier's hands and turns to see the blonde *running full sprint towards her.*

"Oh shit." Catra jumps out of the way with added caution to avoid impaling herself on the sword in her arms.

"I don't want to hurt you." The woman yells.

"Since when does the Horde not want to hurt us?!" Catra yells back with a sneer.

The woman jumps on top of Catra which causes the magicat to cry out. The sword flies out of her hand onto the ground and the Horde soldier is only barely stopped from reaching it by Bow. She rolls and finally reaches her hand out, her fingers barely grazing the handle as a bright light bursts forward from the sword.

Catra covers her eyes reflexively. When she looks back, the woman is unconscious on the ground beside the large sword, no longer enveloped in a bright, white glow.

"What was that?!" Bow yells.

"I don't know. Get her tied up. We can't afford to let her slip away if she can use this thing." Catra picks up the sword and holds onto it in her left hand.

Not my thing. She thinks and lightly swings it around with a chuckle. She has always been more inclined for hand-to-hand style combat.

Catra sits down next to the now-restrained soldier as Bow takes a seat across from her and eyes the woman up and down. The woman then suddenly stirs and bolts up confusedly.

"What happened?" She asks.

"Quiet, Horde spy. I ask the questions around here. How did you make it this far into the Woods?" Catra asks pointedly.

"I just- I just walked in." The woman tilts her head, confused. "And I'm not a spy!"

"You walked into Bright Moon protected territory, finding a piece of First Ones tech that is clearly under our jurisdiction, and tried to steal it. Doesn’t that sound suspicious?" Catra grins.

"But I found it first!" The soldier protests and causes Catra to roll her eyes.

"You found it in our territory. That makes it ours. Come on Bow, let's get her back to Bright Moon." Catra starts towards the inner

part of the woods.

The soldier walks in front of the pair and shuffles towards the center of the woods begrudgingly as Catra and Bow walk behind.

"This'll show her." Catra says.

"Show who?"

"My mom. She’s gonna see I was right and then maybe she'll have to listen to me now. We have a piece of clearly powerful First Ones tech along with a Horde soldier ripe for interrogating. This is perfect." Catra's eyes light up proudly.

I hope I'm making Dad proud.

Catra looks down at Bow's tracker-pad, which just displays static now. "This thing isn't working at all, Bow." She lifts it up and waves it in the air.

"It's fine, I know where I'm going. I practically grew up in these woods." Bow says with a smile.

More than an hour later Catra is growing impatient. "I thought you knew where we were going!?"

"I did until you started leading us every which way!" Bow says, exasperated.

Catra yells in frustration then stomps around for a better signal on the tracker-pad. "Where the hell are we-"

Her eyes settle on a burnt out building in a sea of burnt out buildings, Horde insignias graffitied all over the place. Fear fills Catra's lungs before she takes a deep, strangled breath. She turns tail and begins marching back towards Bow.

She grabs the prisoner by the collar in rage and drags her towards the ruins angrily.

"Ow! What the hell!?" The soldier protests.

Catra dumps her in front of the building. "You see what you people do? You're monsters. You destroy lives."

"No. This wasn't us. The Horde would never-"

"The Horde is known for this kind of destruction. I suggest you get used to it." Catra says coldly.

"Hordak says we're making Etheria a better place. This isn't-"

"HORDAK LIED!" Catra yells. "IS THIS WHAT'S BEST FOR ETHERIA? MINDLESS DESTRUCTION?" She storms off into the woods and uses the sword to hack away at tree limbs and bushes as she goes along.

Suddenly the sword hits something hard, which causes Catra to jump.

Just a rock.

The rock starts to move and suddenly lifts itself up to reveal itself to be a large insect-like beast with rock-like armor.

Catra yells out and runs backwards towards Bow and the prisoner, the beast in hot pursuit. Somewhere along the way the sword slips out of Catra's hand and tumbles onto the ground.

Catra looks up to see Bow taking aim in an attempt to try and lure the beast away. With a few loud *plinks* the arrows barely register against the monster's hard shell.

"Bow! Take the prisoner and-"

The prisoner.

Where the hell was the prisoner?

Catra turns around to see the soldier raising the sword towards the sky. "Wait!" She yells.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" The soldier yells.

Blinding, white light surrounds Catra and Bow like a blanket of snow. When the light finally fades after a few seconds the Horde soldier is gone, replaced instead by a nearly eight-foot tall tower of muscle for a woman who stares right at the beast.

"Catra?" Bow mutters.

"Yea. I-I see her Bow." Catra stutters.

The beast seems to have grown docile at the woman's appearance. Catra uses the opportunity to try to get the sword back. She can't afford this kind of power falling into the Horde's hands.

The woman suddenly yells and stumbles backwards. With a small magical glow she transforms back into the Horde soldier from before.

"What did you do to me?!"

"What do you mean what did I do to you?!" Catra growls and tries to pull the sword out of the blonde's grip.

"I didn't know being a princess was contagious!!" The soldier yells.

"OK EVERYONE CALM DOWN." Bow yells loudly enough to make his own voice crack. He looks at the Horde soldier. "You want to tell us how you did that?"

"I didn't do anything! All I did was pick up the sword and WHOOSH, I'm in a tiara!"

"Bow. It doesn't matter how she did it. We just need to make sure she never does it again." Catra says firmly, pulling the sword out of the blonde's grasp.

This action alone is enough to stir the beast, which begins to follow Catra and Bow behind a large branch. Bow looks around

panickedly, grabbing the sword and holding it out to the soldier.

"Do it again!"

Catra groans, rolling her eyes.

The three run into a clearing. At the center lies a large moss-covered door that Catra doesn't think has been opened in years.

"This looks like a dead end." Catra says.

"No. It's a password." The soldier looks up at the writing. "It says…'Eternia'."

The door slowly opens.

"You can read First Ones writing!?" Catra says with indignation.

"No time to argue!" Bow urges the pair inside the large stone door, which tightly closes shut behind them.

The trio sit for a moment, catching their breath as Catra lights a small makeshift torch.

"Ok, Horde soldier. you want to explain to me how you can read First Ones writing?" Catra growls.

"I don't- I don't know! I just read the words on the door!" The soldier fires back defensively.

"Oh, right. You just read a language no one has spoken in thousands of years by accident and the door opened!" Catra grumbles.

"You think I wanted this? You think I *want* to be a princess?! Princesses are *monsters.* " The venom in the soldier's voice is enough to set Catra off.

"Monsters?! MONSTERS!? You're the MONSTERS?! You kidnapped my sister, a defenseless *child* ! You killed my father and left me with the only person who could never understand me!! *I'm* the monster?!" Catra screams in anger.

"Catra! Calm down. She did save us, after all." Bow tries to mediate.

"I don't care. Have you forgotten everything they've done to us, Bow? We *can't* trust her. We have to get her back to Bright Moon. The only person who will know what to do with her is my mother." Catra turns and leads the group further into the ruins. Bow and

the soldier trail behind as Catra grumpily studies the sword in her hand.

"I'm Bow, by the way." Catra hears Bow say.

"Adora." The Horde soldier replies.

"That's a pretty weird name for a Horde soldier." Bow chuckles.

"Is it? I wouldn't know." Adora responds, uninterested.

Catra looks down at the sword.

I wonder?

"For the Honor of Grayskull." She mutters, seeing if the sword would respond to just anyone.

"Whatcha doing?" Catra jumps as Bow appears beside her.

"I was curious if the sword responded to just anyone!" Catra says defensively.

"Right." Bow grins. "Look at all these First Ones carvings. I wonder what it all means."

"What's a First One?" Adora inquires.

"The original people of Etheria. They disappeared a thousand years ago and left behind all these ancient ruins."

"Adora. Can you give us some light?" Catra turns and eyes the blonde.

"I don't know how to do that."

"I don't know just figure out the First Ones word for light or something." Catra grumbles.

"I don't know *how.* I'm not *magic.* " Adora growls back.

"Clearly. Bow, give me one of your arrows." Catra holds out her hand. When the boy obliges, Catra wraps a piece of kindling around the arrow before lighting it on fire. "Shoot this at those vines up there. I don't think it'll last long but it should be enough to give us some light for a little while."

Bow fires the arrow, lighting up the entire atrium around them. On the wall opposite Catra is a huge mural depicting-

Adora?

"That's you." Catra points.

"What? That doesn’t look anything like me."

"No. Princess you. The you that the sword made." Catra turns, raising an eyebrow. "Just who *are* you?"

Below the large mural was a First Ones inscription lining what appears to be a podium of some sort. Catra jumps up on top of it, crouching down and pointing towards the writing.

"Blondie. What's this say?" She quips.

"It says-" Adora tilts her head. "She-Ra."

The podium lights up at the word, lowering as the entire room begins to glow.

"Welcome, Administrator. What is your query?" A figure appears where the podium once stood.

Catra hisses and jumps back fearfully. "What is that thing?!"

"It's some sort of hologram." Bow observes. "What is this place?"

The hologram stares for a moment. "What is your query?"

"How do we get out of here?" Bow asks, more slowly this time.

"What is your query?" The hologram repeats.

"I think she's…old." Catra touches the hologram, causing the lights to turn red.

"What did you do!?" Bow asks anxiously.

"I don't know I just- just touched it!!" Catra responds.

"Administrator not detected. Initiating lockdown." The hologram says.

"Lockdown!?" Catra yells. "Blondie! You have to stop it!" The building begins to crumble around them.

"I don't know how!" Adora's eyes widen. "Give me the sword. I don't know why, but the lady in the cape is somehow the key to this!"

"No way! Not happening! Got any other plans?" Catra growls.

Suddenly a piece of rubble falls, nearly crushing Catra beneath it. "Run!"

The three run back the way they came, sprinting along as parts of the building fall around them. They come to the first door they came through, still locked tightly shut. In panic Catra begins to claw at the door, slicing through it and creating an opening for them to climb through.

Catra is the last to climb through and as she does a sharp pain suddenly shoots through her head as a sizable piece of stone collides with bone. A flash of light later and she's tumbling to the grass, the world fading in and out around her.

"Catra!" Bow calls. "Catra!"

She rubs her head, coming to a large, wet lump. The last thing she sees before blacking out is the sight of blood on her fingers.

When Catra comes to the world around her is spinning a little more than she'd like. Sitting up immediately sends a thunderbolt of nausea through her body, causing her to empty the contents of her stomach onto the grass.

"Oh god." She mutters.

"You know, I could have told you that was a terrible idea." Bow chuckles, helping her stand.

"Not now." Catra growls, before sighing. "Sorry. Long day. Thanks Bow." Her attention turns to Adora, still standing there staring at the two of them. "Why are you still here?"

"What?" The blonde replies.

"Look. Bow and I are hardly the best security team. You could have gotten away at any point now. Why are you still here?" Catra asks exhaustedly.

"I-" Adora hesitates. "I don't know what's happening to me and if I go back there- back to the Fright Zone, I'll never know. Shadow Weaver never told me where I came from or who my parents were. I just want to know who I am."

Catra's eyes widen as her stomach lurches again, causing her to throw up once more. "The Sh-Shadow Weaver?"

"You know her?" Adora takes a step back.

"She kidnapped my sister." Catra looks away angrily.

"Listen, if anyone can tell you what's going on it's Catra's mom. I promise you she's got more knowledge on the First Ones tech than anyone I know. She'll be our best chance." Bow smiles reassuringly.

"If she doesn't kill me first." Catra mutters.

Bow brushes her off, reaching his hand out to Adora. "Stick with us?"

Adora smiles softly in response.

"There should be a village a few miles from here. They'll be able to get us back to Bright Moon. We've already wasted too much time." Catra says flatly as she walks ahead.

As they approach the village Catra pulls Adora aside, looking her up and down. "The jacket needs to go. They're gonna flip out if they see a Horde soldier." Catra grabs the jacket and tries to pull it off Adora, causing the blonde to smack her hand away.

"I can do it myself thank you." She says as she pulls it off.

"Here. Take this." Catra hands Adora a cloak to help her blend in. "They shouldn't suspect a thing with that."

Adora looks down in disgust. "I feel ridiculous."

"Nonsense! You just need something to tie it all together." Bow grins, picking up a flower and putting it in Adora's hair.

Adora makes a face. "I don't like it."

"Doesn't matter. You look the part. We'll be in and out. Now come on." Catra gestures at Bow and Adora, leading them into the village.

"What is this?" Adora asks, looking around at all the villagers laughing and enjoying themselves.

"It's a festival." Bow says, causing Adora to shoot him a confused look. "Like a big party?"

Adora stares at him blankly.

"You don't have parties in the Fright Zone?!" Bow asks, louder than Catra would like him to.

"Low profile, Bow!" Catra growls.

"Catra! She has never been to a party before! This is serious!" Bow says with a nod.

Catra ends up playing third-wheel to Bow and Adora enjoying the festivities (maybe more than she would like, considering the circumstances). Adora clearly has never seen much of anything outside of drills and ration bars. It actually sort of tugs a little at Catra's heart to see, because as the day goes on Adora looks less like a Horde soldier and more like a sheltered little kid. Catra can't help but see herself in the girl, getting to see the world for the first time. When did she become so bitter?

Cannon fire breaks Catra out of her stupor. "What's going on?"

"The Horde!" Bow calls.

The three duck into a building as Catra tries to come up with a plan quickly. "What do they want with Thaymore? There's nothing here!"

"Thaymore?!" Adora hesitates. "This- this can't be-"

"What do you know about this blondie?!" Catra growls, grabbing Adora by the shoulders.

"This can't be Thaymore. Thaymore's a rebel fortress!" Adora mutters. "I can get them to stop, I just need to talk to them. Get as many people away as you can. Don’t let them see you."

Catra begrudgingly nods. She hates to take orders from a Horde soldier but she knows Adora is right. She gestures at Bow, signaling for him to head the other direction. "Bring them towards the Woods!"

Catra dodges a blast from a bot, sinking her somewhat damaged glove-claws into it.

Shit. That door did a number on them. Need to fix these.

She kicks the bot away, signaling more people to follow her away from the battlefield.

"Catra! I think that's all of them! Let's go!" Bow gestures for Catra to follow. The pair barely duck behind a root in time for a large, floating bot to zoom past in pursuit.

"What do we do?!" Bow asks.

Catra sighs. "I don't think we can do anything. My claws are busted and you're low on arrows. We're dead in the water."

"You can't say that Catra! You're the most brilliant tactician in Bright Moon! You've gotten people out of way tighter spots with less at their disposal!"

"Listen to me Bow. I can't say this lightly. Mom was right. This was a really bad idea and we're worse off for it. We've had barely any luck except for finding that sword and so far that's not proving to be very useful." Catra sighs.

"Catra are you listening to yourself? Who are you!? You're Commander Catra of Bright Moon, one of the most brilliant people I know. I'm a tinkerer, not a genius strategist! You're selling yourself way too short! If Angella doesn't see that then that's her loss!" Bow nods.

Catra looks up at the boy. "Ok. Yeah. You're right." She stands up. "We need to find Adora."

"Adora? Didn't she just abandon us?" Bow asks.

Catra thinks back to that childlike wonder Adora had during the festivities. The kind of wonder only someone who had never seen the outside world could have. She knows that Adora can't have known about this, not now.

"No. She didn't. She probably had no idea. Let's go get her."

The pair run back towards the tank to see another Horde soldier with pink hair shocking Adora with some sort of baton.

"Adora!" Catra yells, distracting the soldier for a moment. Bow fires a net at her, briefly incapacitating her as Catra helps Adora to her feet.

"Let's go." Catra says.

"Why did you come back for me?"

"Because we need you. I don't know how but I know we do." Catra says firmly, holding the sword out for Adora to take. "And I can’t lose this war. Too many people have died and if you're willing to fight for the Rebellion then do it."

Adora shakes her head nervously. "I can't! I'm no princess! I'm a grunt, destined to push people around!"

Catra thrusts the sword into Adora's hands. "Then go push them around."

Adora looks at the sword nervously, before looking up and around at the battlefield. "Ok."

She raises the sword high, voice ringing out the words that invoke the sword's power. With a blinding flash of light, Adora's form changes and replacing her is the tall, muscular warrior.

"Bow!" Catra yells, running towards the legion of tanks now surrounding the tinkerer.

One by one Adora cuts through them like butter. Catra can't help but watch in amazement as Adora fights so naturally. The only thing remaining when the chaos is over is a tower of smoke billowing over Thaymore. In the distance the pink-haired soldier watches as the three celebrate before walking away. Catra can't help but feel like she's familiar. Too familiar.

Her eyes widen when Adora says the soldier's name.

"Glimmer."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much to everyone who beta read!

Flowers for Catra

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer gets a new mission while Catra and company head to Plumeria to recruit it's princess.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You went directly against my wishes and then you brought a *Horde soldier* into Bright Moon?!" Angela's brow furrows in clear frustration and she lets out a huff that reminds Catra all too much of herself.

"Mom, I know how this looks-" Catra starts.

"No, Catra, clearly you don't! You've defied my wishes three times now! If you continue I will be forced to strip you of your title and command!" Angella continues to rant angrily, her words echoing all around the throne room and causing Catra's rage to begin to bubble just under the surface. At any moment it could boil over and Catra knows that once the pair got into it there was no going back for either of them.

"MOM!" Catra yells loudly enough to cause herself to run out of breath. The words catch in her throat as she struggles to form them. She hasn't grappled quite yet with the implications of it all and now she was about to reveal a devastating truth to Angella that very well might break her.

She swallows, takes a deep breath, and finally the words rush out with a violence she doesn’t expect. "Glimmer is alive."

A vacuum seems to open between them, strangling the air and emotion from around Catra and her mother. It was on the day he died, Catra knew, that Micah had gone after a lead on Glimmer in some desperate hope to finally find her. Now that Catra knows exactly who Glimmer is, she wasn't sure how to feel.

Angella's eyes widen with an almost fearful twitch. "What?"

"The Horde soldier knows her." Catra's mood begins to drop gradually, she can feel it. It's slipping from pride into her usual state of emotional catatonia, rage and sadness sharpening the pauses between her words like thorns. This day just keeps draining her more and more and eventually she is going to end up face down in her bed, she feels. "There's something else. The blonde, Adora, has some kind of magical power. She turned into this warrior princess. She-Ra. You're old, have you heard of her?"

Angella doesn't say a word, her eyes seeming to glaze over as Catra watches her contemplate everything she's just said. Catra can't help but feel a hint of frustration that embellishes the numbing, deafening sadness lining her mood. She knows her mother is in shock. Hell, Catra wouldn't know how to respond either, considering she just found out her sister is alive and is a Horde soldier and now apparently this thousand year old sword princess is going to save the world. So why does she feel so angered by it? Why does she want her mother to just say something already and break the silence?

Catra's jolted out of her thoughts by Angella suddenly crumpling to the ground gracelessly, a thud echoing throughout the chamber.

"Mom!"

Glimmer eyes herself angrily in the mirror. She could have stopped Adora if she had just paid attention. She could have kept her from leaving. How could she do such a thing? Did Adora really think she was so much better than Glimmer? After everything Glimmer did for her?

Adora was so stupid. So naive. If she had just stayed, everything wouldn't have to be so complicated. Adora had Glimmer and Glimmer could keep her safe from Shadow Weaver. Now Adora's got her stupid new friends and high and mighty attitude. She really must hate Glimmer, even after everything she did.

"Glimmer." Glimmer jumps at the sound of Shadow Weaver's voice behind her. She turns around and salutes.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver?"

"Tell me everything that happened at Thaymore. I want details. *Now.* " Weaver's voice cuts through Glimmer's shell like knives,

tearing into her darkest insecurities. Glimmer knows she was the prized possessions of the witch, but that never meant Shadow Weaver treated her with any amount of respect.

Glimmer's face drops as she lets out a loud groan. "What is there to say? She left us. She wants nothing to do with us anymore. With *me.* "

"But *what* exactly did you see?" The knives press even further into Glimmer's flesh, past the now broken shell and digging into her skin.

"She turned into a princess. A tall lady with a sword." Glimmer relents.

"She *what?* " Shadow Weaver reels backwards in horror.

"Yea. There. Happy?" Glimmer rolls her eyes.

"You dare talk back to me, child. After every opportunity I have given you?" Shadow Weaver circles Glimmer ominously. "Know your place or I will teach you. You may be a force captain, Glimmer, but don't you dare forget that *I* put you there."

Fear climbs Glimmer's spine like lightning. Out of dread she drops to her knee, bowing before the commander. "Yes, Shadow Weaver."

Adora paces back and forth inside her cell (could she even call this that? It was more like a spare room), pangs of anxiety coming and going like jabs of a knife as she keeps herself moving. She briefly considers lying down in the bed behind her, but decides against it. The movement offers some sort of stimulation, keeping her momentarily alert compared to the alternative. What was she doing out here? She should have just brought the sword back to the Fright Zone. She's way in over her head.

Adora doesn't realize she's stopped as she stares at her reflection in a mirror hanging just across from the bed, looking at her long, blonde locks that tumble down over her shoulders. She used to prefer it being up, but some time ago she lost a lot of her will to keep it that way. People made fun of the way her hair used to poof up at the top, calling her dumb names to boot. Better to fly under the radar than grow defensive, she thinks.

A knock at the door startles Adora, causing her to jump in the air. She worries whoever it is might have heard her stumble over herself as she walks to the door, her hand wrapping around the knob tightly without turning it. She freezes, not ready to face whoever it is on the other side. This was never supposed to happen this way. But still she steadies herself and takes a deep breath as she turns the knob , coming face to face with Commander Catra.

"Everything ok? Did you fall?" Catra asks in her usual, gruff tone, eyeing the room carefully.

"I'm fine. You just startled me." Adora quietly admits , looking back to Catra for any kind of reaction. Catra instead balls her hands into fists and sulks before sighing.

"I need you to come with me to the infirmary."

"The infirmary? Wh-why?" Adora stutters.

"You need to tell the queen everything about Glimmer." Catra says, not meeting Adora's eyes.

"Glimmer? What's Glimmer got to do with anything?"

Catra looks up with a stubborn chuckle. "Everything."

"Hold on. Glimmer is your *sister* ?" Adora's words come out faster than she's able to process what Catra's just said.

Catra nods. "My parents told me the Horde took her when we were really little, not long after I was adopted."

"Adopted?" Adora tilts her head, causing Catra to stare at her in slight confusion.

"Yea. Adopted." Catra huffs, shrugging.

"Oh. Right. Adopted." Adora chuckles nervously. "What's adopted mean?"

Catra stops cold. "Adora, please tell me I don't have to explain adoption to you."

"Oh no of course not. I might just- need a reminder?" Adora grins.

Catra groans loudly, covering her face with her hand. "Adoption is where your parents aren't related to you but they take you in as their child anyways. I wasn't born in Bright Moon and never knew my real parents."

"Oh. So like Shadow Weaver."

Catra makes a face, turning towards Adora. "Shadow Weaver?"

"She kind of raised Glimmer and I? I don't think she likes me very much. Glimmer was her favorite." Adora shrugs, not really putting much more thought into it.

"Ok, but what kind of a name is Shadow Weaver? That has to be the most hokey name ever." Catra laughs squeakily.

The pair arrive at the large, extravagant set of doors leading into the infirmary. Adora recognizes this and feels herself immediately straighten up to soldier stance. She has to make a good impression if she's ever going to fit in here. Maybe she can just be another fighter on the front lines for them. Could she really fight her old friends after so little time?

A taller woman ushers them inside. Juliet, she hears Catra call her. One of Bright Moon's Generals who has apparently been keeping an eye on things down here. Adora finds herself suddenly wondering what it is they are doing here in the first place. Was the queen visiting some patients?

The answer quickly comes to Adora as she sees Queen Angella sitting up in an infirmary bed, her nose buried in a book as the pair approach.

"What happened?" Adora whispers.

"She fainted. She'll be fine. She didn't even want to come." Catra whispers back.

"That is one way you and I are much alike, daughter." The queen chuckles, her tone amused. "Though I suggest being quieter if you are trying not to include me."

Catra turns bright red, her tail becoming bushy as she looks down and away from her mother. "Sorry. Didn't mean to."

Angella chuckles and shakes her head. "I love you dearly, child." Her expression turns somber as she turns to look at Adora. She seems to hesitate, a silence lingering as the Queen considers her words. "I want you to tell me all about Glimmer."

Adora nods, considering carefully where to start before settling on the first time they met. "Glimmer and I were- were friends. We met as kids. I was probably four or five? I remember Shadow Weaver bringing her back to the Fright Zone and it was like everything changed." Adora can see Angella's face sour at the mention of Shadow Weaver.

"I have no further use for you Adora. I have found someone much more special." Shadow Weaver had said. Weaver had fawned over Adora for years and suddenly it was like she didn't even know who she was. Adora was destined to become another cog in the machine.

"Glimmer d-defended me a lot. Shadow Weaver must have seen me as competition for her even though I'm not magic or anything. I don't know why but Glimmer was- she helped." The memories

pain Adora as she realizes that Glimmer probably hates her now after all this.

Catra raises an eyebrow, seemingly noticing her mother's reaction to all this. "Do you know her, mom?"

"She kidnapped our Glimmer. We thought for sure she was dead but- no" Angella breaks into a sob. "It was so much worse."

"Worse how?" Catra is beginning to become frustrated as she realizes she's out of the loop. "Who is Shadow Weaver?"

Angella's tears roll down her cheeks as she looks up from the bed to Catra. "An evil, evil witch who has taken countless lives."

Catra deflates. "So she wanted Glimmer for herself. For power." She shakes her head. "Ok. Fine. Maybe we can talk her out of it. Maybe we can convince her to come back to Bright Moon."

"I tried." Adora sighs. "At Thaymore. I did my best. She refused to come with us. She was so angry at everything. It's all my fault."

"Adora, honey. None of this is your fault." Angella reassures.

Catra looks down at her hands, trying to dissuade the fear and anxiety washing over her as she realizes exactly what this means. Her hands begin to shake, half with rage, half with fear, as she balls them into fists and looks up at Angella.

"That means Glimmer is the enemy."

Glimmer screams at the top of her lungs as her fists find the wall by her bunk. The bunk that she and Adora shared, where every night the pair slept for close to twenty years.

She slams her hand against it, finding a drawing the two had made as children taped onto the wall. An irrational impulse comes to her, magic beginning to glow in her gloved palm as her fist flies forward again, slamming against the drawing, burning it to cindersleaving a large burn over it.

"Are you ok?" A male voice inquiresasks from behind her. Glimmer turns to find Kyle staring at her with concern, pity. and who she sees only makes her angrier.

"FUCK OFF KYLE!" Glimmer yells at top of her lungs, she cant let anyone, especially Kyle see her like this, see her so weak.. Kyle jumps backwards with a yelp, shuffling quickly out of the room, muttering various apologies..

Glimmer lays back on the bed, defeated. Adora has new friends now. She doesn't need her. Maybe in some way, Glimmer is proud of Adora. After all the times she stood up for the girl against Shadow Weaver, Adora finally learned to stand up for herself.

Or maybe Adora has finally snapped. Maybe she has an ego comparable to her giant forehead that was always waiting to put Glimmer down. Maybe she just thinks Glimmer is beneath her.

Glimmer is almost certain she's right about that as she lets out a final groan of frustration.

Hours later Adora sits in silence in her makeshift prison/bedroom. She keeps wondering if there is some way she can get out of this. Some way to just leave and never have to be anything more than a blip in the eyes of these people. She dislikes the spotlight her newfound powers have put her in, forcing her to be somebody she doesn’t want to be. She wishes Glimmer was here, honestly, because then Glimmer could maybe talk her into all this. Glimmer always saw more in Adora than Adora did herself.

Adora silently kicks her legs against the frame of the bed she sits on, wistfully pondering everything Catra and Angella had said. Glimmer was, for better or for worse, her enemy now. She hadn’t wanted to come with Adora back in Thaymore and had gotten angrier than Adora had ever seen her. She groans loudly as she

stands up and starts to pace around the room. She can still feel the place tingling where Glimmer stabbed her with the baton in anger, sending waves of pain down her right leg. She never asked for this- no, maybe she did. She went after that stupid sword and bit off more than she can chew. Maybe she deserves Glimmer's hatred.

Another loud knock at the door stirs Adora from her thoughts. She just can't escape people today, it seems. She-Ra has been the talk9 of the town ever since she arrived. Adora stands and pulls the door open to see Catra's face once again. This time Catra looks nervous, the womans strong facade broken

"Hey. What's up?" Catra grins half-heartedly.

"Oh uh- im fine i guess,just thinking.. Do you need something, commander?" Adora says taken aback by the commanders lack of formality. She suspiciously examines her, only to notice the familiar sword held tightly in Catra's left hand.

. "My mother is giving you a trial run. Well, no, actually she's giving both of us a trial run. She's agreed to allow me to rebuild the Princess Alliance and let you stay as long as things go well enough today. Get your things together, we're heading to Plumeria as soon as we get Bow." Catra holds the sword out to Adora, practically thrusting it into her hands.

"Plum-what-now?" Adora says, confused.

"Plumeria. They're a bunch of hippie flower people. Nice enough, but a little strange. We're gonna go see if they want to help us rebuild the rebellion. Their prince hasn't been seen in years, but

rumor has it a relative of his has taken his place. Come on.” Catra gestures Adora out the door and down the hall.

"So, what do you want me to do? Wave this around and hope the sword-lady wows them?" Adora huffs.

"Yes and no. We're gonna have a proper diplomatic meeting with them, we just need a reason. You're our reason. We've sent a message saying She-Ra is back and they want to meet you." Catra's footsteps echo as her boots tap against the floor.

"Oh. So I'm an in. Ok. I see." Adora shrugs.

Catra raises an eyebrow. "I mean, you're more than that. Not just an in but an asset."

"Not sure what makes me an asset other than the sword-lady. You're putting a lot of faith in me. I'm no one. Another cog in the machine."

"Adora, I don't know what they told you back in the horde but I have seen you fight and you are not that bad. You're selling yourself too short." Catra offers gruffly, causing Adora to sigh.

"Ok. Yea. Sorry." Adora shakes her head. "When you're only told one thing your entire life you just start to believe it."

“I get it, I just don’t like seeing you put yourself down. You’re better than that.”

Adora chuckles. "Aw, you must really like me then."

Catra's face turns bright red as she looks away quickly. "No! Not in a million years. Shut up!"

Adora grins as the pair reach the entrance to Bright Moon. Bow waits for them patiently, eyeing his little tappy device carefully as Catra waves at him.

"Hey Arrow Boy. Ready?"

Bow looks up and smiles. "Ready as I'll ever be. I'm surprised she gave you this chance."

Catra gestures at Adora. "Wouldn't have without her, to be honest. Gotta give Adora some credit."

At this Adora blushes and looks down at her feet, quietly following Catra and Bow out of the safety of Bright Moon and deep into the gaping maw of the Whispering Woods.

Glimmer's mood is shot. She doesn't want to hear from anyone, talk to anyone or even see anyone.,All she can think about is how much she hates Adora. Even that day she left had to be dramatic of her.

"The Horde is evil, Glimmer!" Adora yelled over the sounds of cannonfire.

Glimmer scowls at Adora incredulously. "Yea? How'd you reckon that? The fact that we're officially called 'the Evil Horde?' Or was it the oppression?"

"You-" Adora scoffs. "You knew?"

"Yeah I knew! I've always known. Did you ever wonder why I had to protect you all the time? Because Shadow Weaver is evil!" Glimmer's anger begins to peek through the cracks in her composure.

"You never needed to protect me! I can hold my own!"

"What, so now you think you're better than me?" Ringing overtakes all other sounds in her ears as Glimmer's thoughts spiral into darkness. "You think now you can just leave me? After everything we did for each other?"

"I can't stay. Come with me, Glimmer. We can leave the Horde together." Adora says calmly.

The ringing explodes into hatred.

"You think-" Glimmer starts to chuckle. "You think you can give up everything we know? Our way of life? And expect me to just follow you? You've lost it, Adora. You've fucking lost it." Glimmer continues to chuckle as Adora looks on in concern.

"Glimmer, that's not true. I never wanted to abandon you I-" Adora's sentence is cut short as Glimmer shocks her with the stun baton.

"Shut up."

"Where's Adora?" Bow suddenly asks as they approach Plumeria. Catra looks around, having apparently lost the blonde.

"Goddammit. I knew she was being too quiet. ADORA!"

A cracking noise echoes from behind them as She-Ra stands up, lifting a decrepit cart into the air. Catra scoffs, rolling her eyes.

"Are you going to be She-Ra this entire time?" She grumbles.

"Well, your mom did say people might like me better this way. I'm not going to argue with her." Adora smiles, lifting the cart high into the air.

"Everyone look!" A shrill, unfamiliar voice echoes beyond the group.

Catra turns to see a tall, attractive woman with flowers in her long blonde hair running towards them.

"You came!" The Plumerian woman says, looking between Catra and Bow.

"Yes! I'm Commander Catra of Bright Moon and this is Tech Master Bow. Are you Princess Perfuma?" Catra asks formally.

"Indeed I am. We're so delighted to-" Perfuma's sentence is cut off as she sees something behind Catra.

Catra turns to see Adora, who is setting the cart down and approaching them.

"Oh my! It really is you! Come everyone, look!" Perfuma grins, apparently ecstatic to see She-Ra. "The universe has heard our pleas! She-Ra has come to end the blockade!"

Catra finds herself quietly captivated by Perfuma for some reason. She quickly dismisses in favor of the task at hand. "Princess Perfuma, would you mind showing She-Ra around?"

"Of course! I would be overjoyed!" Perfuma gestures for the group to follow her, walking towards the group of buildings making up Plumeria. "We Plumerians are known, of course, for our beautiful flowers and majestic trees, but the real star of the show is this!" She gestures at a giant tree with a large glowing rock encased inside of it. "This is our runestone and the source of my magical powers!"

"Hold on." Catra stops. "Your magical powers? Are you the old prince's sister then?" She eyes Perfuma up and down. "Because you don't typically just *get* the powers of a runestone without being born with it.

"Prince?" Perfuma raises an eyebrow. "There’s never been any prince here. Only me!"

"There was though. A blonde-haired prince of Plumeria, supposedly roughly my age." Catra grills Perfuma a little harder. She doesn't quite understand what Perfuma is covering up.

Perfuma bursts into hysterical laughter. "Oh. Oh my! I think I understand the error here. *I* am the blonde-haired-" She raises her fingers in air quotes. "prince." She shakes her head, giggling. "It's understandable. We didn't keep in contact with you so you never got the message. I've understood myself as Perfuma for far longer than I ever did as the 'prince.'" She grins. "I am still the same old ruler of Plumeria, I assure you."

Catra nods. "I understand. Makes way more sense than the story we had." She chuckles. "We thought you were some kind of cousin or something."

"I assure you I am not my own cousin." Perfuma grins.

Adora looks around confusedly. "So are we meeting the prince then?"

Bow's hand meets his face as he laughs loudly. "No Adora. Perfuma is the prince. Or, used to be. She's a princess now."

"Ohhhh." Adora looks down at her sword. "Wait, I don't get it."

Catra groans. "Ok. Let me be super simple. Perfuma was a prince. She was not happy as a prince. She decided to become a princess instead. She is happier as a princess."

"Oh." Adora grins and flashes a thumbs up of understanding.

"At least this tree isn't dying." Bow mutters.

Perfuma looks down somberly. "The blight hit right after the Horde arrived. I'm- I'm sure they have something to do with it but-" She hesitates. "Plumerians aren't fighters. We're peaceful, nature loving people." Perfuma paces for a moment before looking up excitedly. "But now that you're here maybe you can help us! Maybe we can heal Plumeria!" She grabs hold of Adora's arm.

"Princess Perfuma, we're here to help, of course, but-" Catra pauses hesitantly. "We can't do it alone. We need you and your people. This is your land and you'll know it best for how we can stop the Horde."

"There won't be any need for fighting. She-Ra can use her powers to heal our land." Perfuma says firmly.

"I can?" Adora looks around confusedly. Catra nudges her with her elbow. "I mean, of course I can! Just as soon as I talk to Bow and Catra alone in those trees over there!" Adora drags Catra and Bow into the small wooded area, her demeanor breaking as soon as they're out of sight. "I don't know what I'm doing. I've never healed anything before!"

Glimmer paces the Force Captain meeting room back and forth. She's supposed to be receiving her assignment soon, but it's been nearly an hour and absolutely nothing. She's getting bored and impatient. Almost about to leave, she stops when the door opens and steps through Shadow Weaver, followed by a tall, stark haired woman with-

Scorpion Claws?

"Force Captain Glimmer, meet Force Captain Scorpia. You two will be assigned to the Dryl mission." Shadow Weaver commands.

"Dryl mission?" Glimmer tilts her head in confusion.

"Princess Entrapta will be a major asset to the Rebellion cause and they will likely attempt to recruit her next. I want you to arrive first and capture her. If she does not cooperate, you know what to do." Shadow Weaver says coldly.

Glimmer's stomach drops as she swallows. "Yes, Shadow Weaver."

"I will leave you two to it." The witch promptly exits the room, unnervingly making no sounds as she does.

Glimmer looks at the very large, muscular scorpion woman. "So, Scorpia huh? Did your parents run out of names?"

"Oh, it runs in our family. Every few princesses gets to be named Scorpia!" The woman says a little too cheerfully for Glimmer.

"Uh-huh. So do you know any-" Glimmer starts.

"I *love* your hair. Is that your natural color? Mine is white, most people think I'm super stressed out all the time but it's genetic! Someone once asked how I use a pair of scissors to cut it but I don't! Just the ole pincers!" Scorpia rambles on for a few minutes longer about her hair routine.

Oh great, she's a talker.

"The stories *do* say you have healing powers." Bow offers, unhelpfully.

"They also say I had a magic horse. YOU AREN'T HELPING!" Adora scoffs, turning away.

"Ok. Maybe if you concentrate we'll get there. Focus." Catra says calmly, offering her hands to Adora.

Adora takes them and breathes a deep breath. "Ok." She turns, focusing the energy in her hands on a tree before a powerful blast of magic blows some branches off it.

"Well, that certainly was something, but we're not trying to kill anyone here blondie." Catra laughs hoarsely.

"Ok. Let's try that again." Bow says.

Adora closes her eyes, lifting the sword up and pointing it towards Catra and Bow. The sword glows, about the unleash another blast of energy more powerful than the last. Catra realizes this and pushes herself and Bow out of the way nearly too late as the bolt of magic whizzes over her head.

"Adora! Don't point the fucking sword at *us* !" Catra growls in frustration.

Adora groans loudly before punching a tree. Her hands continue to fly, angrily knocking the tree over and smashing it to pieces before groaning and collapsing to the ground and transforming back into her normal self, her hands meeting her face. "I can't do this, Catra. I wasn't meant to be She-Ra. I'm just some girl, not these people's savior."

"You-" Perfuma's voice cuts through like a knife as Adora looks up, her eyes meeting the flower Princess's. "You can't save us?" Perfuma's face turns from shock to disappointment, before settling

on an emotion Adora knows too well: Rage. "You *lied* to my people. You *lied* to me. If you can't save us then why are you even here? My home is *dying* and you were supposed to stop it! Everything we've ever known is crumbling!"

"Princess Perfuma, if I may-" Catra starts.

"Shut up. SHUT UP!" Perfuma growls. "I don't want you or Angella's stupid war propaganda. I want to save my *home* . I know you want me to join your little Alliance but there won't be any Plumeria for me to represent soon." Perfuma turns and walks away, leaving the trio sitting alone amongst the rubble Adora created.

Adora balls her hands into fists, climbing to her feet. "If we can’t save Plumeria then at the very least we'll avenge it."

Catra, Bow, and Adora approach the entrance to the Horde encampment stealthily. Well, less stealthily than Catra would like, but Adora is more of a 'punch first' kind of woman. There's supposed to be a shift change soon and that's what Adora says she's counting on.

"Alright, shift change in fifteen seconds, then we rush in during the distraction." Adora nods, throwing a thumbs up to Catra and

Bow. For someone who hates leadership the woman is a natural, at least to Catra.

"Go!" Adora mutters. The three rush through the gates of the blockade into a large, circular room. Roots cover the walls and ceiling, growing out from a larger central root.

Catra can see that the Horde is injecting some kind of poison into the root. "This must be what's killing the plants. If we can shut it down-"

Her sentence is interrupted by a Horde soldier opening the door. "What are you three doing in here? Do you have clearance?"

Adora rattles off some kind of code faster than Catra can register what she said. The soldier eyes the trio up and down before shutting the door. "That code's out of date."

Their only way out is blocked by the soldier. Catra looks at Adora and Bow before begrudgingly raising her hands in the air.

"What do we do?" Catra mutters.

"Run."

The trio's escape from the poison chamber was rather simple. Catra kicked the soldier's legs out from underneath them and they quickly took the opportunity to make their getaway.

What is proving not so simple is how they are going to fight the increasing number of Horde soldiers currently chasing them. Catra counted between eight and a dozen of them. The three only barely had a chance to catch their breath as they leaped over a wall before the screaming group of grunts came around to surround them.

"Ok. This looks bad. Adora, go left. Bow stay back. I'll take the rest." Catra extends her claws from her gloves, hurdling herself at the nearest soldier.

She jumps from soldier to soldier, clawing and slashing through their armor before one twists her arm behind her back. Adora and Bow are quickly subdued as well as the three are forced to the ground. Catra swears she can see a vine moving behind some of the soldiers, but her vision is quickly blocked as they move in front of her.

Suddenly, as if the ground came alive and sought revenge, vines erupted all around Catra, picking each Horde soldier up and flinging them every which way. The trio stand up, watching as Princess Perfuma approaches with a somber expression. She looks up at the Horde blockade and Catra swears she sees a flash of hatred in the woman's eyes as the princess raises a hand, forcing

plants of every kind through the cracks and crevices of the building, tearing it apart piece by piece.

"No more." She growls, tearing the buildings apart to expose the poison injecting machine. "You will not hurt my people any longer."

With a swift motion the vines grab hold of the machine, tearing it from the roots and smashing it to pieces on the ground. Almost immediately the land seems to regenerate, poison retreating from the plants of Plumeria.

Princess Perfuma turns to look at Adora and Catra. "Are you alright?"

"Yea. We'll be alright." Catra chuckles. "That was really something you just did."

"I did what I had to. Surely you would do the same for Bright Moon." Perfuma nods, a smile finally finding its way to her face. "I will join your Alliance, Catra, if not to destroy the Horde but to protect Plumeria."

Perfuma's eyes meet Catra's as she reaches a hand out. Catra nods in response, taking the flower Princess's hand and shaking it to signify their newfound alliance.

Cheers erupt around them, startling Catra as the people of Plumeria come out from everywhere to greet Perfuma.

Catra looks at Adora, who’s staring disappointedly at the sword. "You did your best Adora. No. Better. You did amazing." Catra offers with a small smile.

"If I did so great then why do I feel like I let everyone down? That was all Perfuma, not me. I'm no warrior. It shouldn’t be me."

"Just because you don't think it should have been you means anyone else could do it better. You were born to do this, you just gotta learn how." Bow grins. "Sometimes that takes a while."

Adora smiles sadly. "Maybe you're right. But what if it's too late for me to be of any use to Bright Moon?"

"Hey now, you're not a tool. We're your friends and even if it was regular old Adora helping us out that would still be something, got it?" Catra grins smugly.

At this, Adora seems to cheer up a bit. "Yea. Ok. Thanks guys."

"I want to thank you personally, Adora." Perfuma smiles, reapproaching the three. "If you hadn't come here I don't think I would have seen the error of my ways. Plumeria needed someone

to push the Horde back and you helped me see that. You're so much more than She-Ra, I know it."

Adora rubs the back of her head and blushes. "Aw, well, shucks."

Bow grins. "This calls for a group hug!"

Catra's eyes go wide. "No, no, no. No hugs. No-" Her sentence is cut off by the three of them squeezing her tightly. "Oh god. My fucking bones."

Glimmer sits quietly on her bunk, staring at the force captain badge she'd been given- no, that she'd *earned* . To think she'd only been a Force Captain for a few weeks. It all happened so fast: Glimmer was promoted just hours before Adora left- no, *abandoned* the Horde. It all has culminated in her first mission with Scorpia. The Dryl mission. It's been bumped up because the Rebellion recruited that flower princess a few days ago and they want her to intercept this one.

"Ready to go, stormbird?" Scorpia's voice bellows around the corner, startling Glimmer.

Stormbird?

"Don't call me that." Glimmer groans. She hates nicknames.

"What? It fits. The wings? The lightning? Come on! Stormbird." Scorpia grins innocently.

Glimmer groans even louder, laying back on the bunk for a moment before standing up, back to Scorpia. "Come on." She grumbles, gesturing towards the door. "Time to get moving."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much for my beta readers and for all the support!

Sequence Collapse

Chapter Summary

> Adora ends up in a race to Dryl in order to secure the inventor Princess Entrapta. With Glimmer and Scorpia hot on her tail, she's forced to face her past before everything crumbles around her.

Chapter Notes

> We're back! Been a while but I have been hard at work on these chapters!
>
> The usual content warnings apply, in addition to gender dysphoria and depression for this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fear fills Adam's body, the evil presence going stronger and stronger. Darkness seems to close in on the edges of his vision as the presence takes hold, the very fibers of his soul being completely enclosed in dread.

The voice that cuts through that dread like a sword is the last one he'd like to hear ever again. The voice of a woman he wants nothing to do with. The voice of Shadow Weaver.

"Adam-" Shadow Weaver's cold, uncaring voice comes crashing through the fog. "Just what do you think you're doing?"

Adam stands up straight, grinning nervously. "Nothing! Nothing, Shadow Weaver. Just trying to help Glimmer pass the exam!"

"And so you thought to help her by-" Shadow Weaver's tone grows angry. "Cheating?"

"No! No! I didn't know it was cheating! I was just-" What comes next is a feeling by this point Adam should be familiar with. The feeling of electrical shocks coursing through his body, firing every nerve and causing his body to tense up against his will.

Adam collapses to the ground, yelling out in pain as Shadow Weaver lurks over her.

"Never again, Adam. You and Glimmer are to be split up. No more of your-" Shadow Weaver scoffs. "Interfering."

"Sh-shadow Weaver." Adam groans. "I didn't mean anything by it. I just wanted to-"

"Silence! Not one more word, boy, or you will suffer the consequences!" The dark magician booms.

"B-but-" Adam's sentence is cut off by another electrical shock, more powerful than the first. It only seems to get stronger as he convulses in agony, screaming at the top of his lungs.

It's this screaming that Adora carries into the real world, waking up yelling so hard she's surprised she isn't losing her voice. Her breathing is so heavy and fast she shouldn't be conscious right now, the breaths coming in and out like hurricane-force winds into her lungs. When she raises her hands to her face they're shaking so hard she thinks there's still a remnant of Shadow Weaver's black magic coursing through it. The fiery, chronic pain starts coursing through them as though they recognize the fear and panic well enough to become real.

Tears begin to flow down Adora's face as anxious, racing thoughts turn into sobs. She cries softly at first, not wanting to alarm anyone, before the pain becomes too much and the tears come too hard to suppress. The memory doesn't want to go away, the events repeating like a broken record through her mind so quickly and so realistically it's difficult to discern exactly where she is and which reality is real.

Like a volcano beginning to erupt she can feel the cries of terror coming. The yelling that she knows is going to alert everyone in the castle. She has to stay quiet. She *needs* to stay quiet. Adora looks around for anything she can use to suppress them and as she turns around back towards the pillows *she's transported back to her bunk in the Horde.*

He looks around, stunned. Exactly as the day she left. The drawing she and Glimmer made still hangs on the wall behind the bunk.

Adam can feel the words of denial beginning to spill out of her mouth. "No. No no no no." She mutters. Soon the same cold feeling of dread fills him up to his neck, threatening to drown her.

That's when she sees the tendrils of a dark shadow lurking beyond the door to the barracks. She knows Adam is here.

Adam screams as Shadow Weaver's form comes into view from through the doorway. "NO NO NO! YOU'RE NOT REAL!" Adora cries as she's jolted back into reality. She looks up from where she sat frozen in fear on the bed and clutching a pillow, to see Catra's worried mismatched eyes staring back at her.

"ADORA!" Catra is yelling, seeming nearly as scared as Adora. Her hands are on Adora's shoulders, shaking her back to real life for a moment.

"C-Catra?" Adora mutters, breathing like she just came up from the longest freedive.

"Oh thank god. You're ok." Catra unexpectedly pulls Adora into a tight hug, something she was not prone to do normally. Adora must really have worried her.

"Sorry." Adora has stopped screaming now, but tears continue to roll down her cheeks as she grapples with the panic attack. "I'm sorry, Catra. I didn't mean to."

"Didn't mean to what, Adora?" Catra pulls out of the hug, resting her hands on Adora's shoulders.

"Worry you. S-sorry." Adora starts to cry again, this time more out of sorrow than fear.

"Oh hush, dummy. I'd be a bad person if I didn't come to check on you after you started screaming bloody murder." Catra chuckles softly. "Are you ok?"

Adora shakes her head. "N-no."

"You wanna talk about it?" Catra tilts her head curiously.

“NO!” Adora growls, causing Catra to reel back. Adora's face falls as guilt washes over her like floodwaters in a hurricane. "I'm sorry."

Catra puts her hand on Adora's shoulder, leaning into a sort of half-hug. She's clearly never consoled someone before and it would almost amuse Adora any other day of the week.

"I'm sorry." Adora repeats, causing Catra's grip on her to tighten a little.

"Don't be." Catra's voice comes out as small and comforting as Adora believes she can muster. "Wanna tell me what you dreamt about?"

"My-" Adora hesitates. "Shadow Weaver."

"That old witch can't hurt you here, Adora." Catra says softly.

"Not here. No. But back there-" Adora gasps as she feels herself being pulled into another flashback. The sensation of air moving around her is stopped only by the ground reality of Catra's body against hers.

"Hey, don't worry about it. I get it. When I was younger-" Catra scoffs. "Well, a few years ago, at least, I used to have dreams about my dad. That somehow I'd let him die. Like-" Catra scoffs again, this time with a tone of self-loathing. "Like I'd let him die. Like if he hadn't found me in that burning building he somehow would still be around today."

Catra's arm pulls off Adora's shoulder, and the blonde watches as her hands meet her face. "I spent so long wondering what would have happened that day. If maybe I had just convinced him not to go. But I couldn't, not when he was still looking for Glimmer. And now I know she's alive and she probably-" Catra groans. " *Hates* me."

"She-" Adora sucks in a deep, labored breath. "She doesn't know you. And if she hates you just for existing then that's not your fault." The blonde's hands shake as she reaches around Catra's shoulders, pulling the commander into a tight hug.

Catra's eyes go wide with a mixture of surprise and discomfort. Adora pulls away, looking down at her legs. "Sorry. I should have asked."

"It's ok. Don't worry about it." Catra says with a guilty, uncomfortable tone. "We're going to Dryl today. Are you gonna be ok?"

Adora looks away from Catra. "I'll- I'll be fine. Don't worry about me. It'll pass and I'll be the same as always."

"Are you sure?" Catra asks, concerned.

"Yes, Catra, I'm sure." Adora growls irritably.

"Ok, ok. Grumpy." Catra giggles. "I just wanna make sure!"

The pair sit together for many more minutes, the darkness of the night beginning to pull them back towards sleep. Before Adora knows it, Catra is out like a light, and she can feel herself being dragged towards it as well, albeit kicking and screaming. Her efforts are in vain, though, as she's overcome by the blackness of sleep.

"Can you fly with those wings or are they too small?" Scorpia asks innocently.

Does she ever stop talking? Glimmer thinks to herself rather cruelly as her feet stomp along the gravel path towards Dryl the same way they have for hours now. She probably could have teleported them, but having never been to the place before they also might have ended up minced up in a machine somewhere. She wasn't even entirely sure if this was the right way anymore. They had walked up a rather dull path around a small mountain that turned out to be one in a sea of mountains with identical gravel paths. Sure the map says they're going the right way, but Scorpia has also talked so much in the last few hours that Glimmer has no idea if she got turned around anywhere. They couldn't even go based on any cardinal direction because the sun was blocked by dark clouds.

Finally, Glimmer snaps, crying out in frustration and grabbing Scorpia by the arm. She's trying to teleport somewhere, *anywhere* , that isn't here.

When the pair land back on the ground Glimmer looks around for a moment at the same gravel path and the same mountain. At least, it looks like it could be, they all look like that. It isn't until she turns around that she knows exactly where they are.

"Oh FUCK you." Glimmer screams, looking back at she and Scorpia's burned footprints only a hundred or so feet back.

"They said it's pretty far, stormbird. I don't think any amount of cheating is going to make this faster." Scorpia says, sounding slightly amused.

"Cheating?! Is this a game to you, Scorpia!?"

"No. But they say it's about the journey, not the destination, right?" The large scorpion woman smiles.

Glimmer considers snarling at Scorpia before she finds that she can't help but back off. The woman's attitude is trying to be contagious and Glimmer doesn't like it at all. She wants nothing to do with whatever this happy, carefree energy is right now.

So the pair trot on, gravel crunching under Glimmer's even heavier stomping now as they continue to walk the spiraling path around this mountain. Glimmer swears she sees a building in the distance but chalks it up to exhaustion.

Adora’s feet hurt as she walks along the gravel path towards Dryl. Mountains line the edges of her vision, towering over she, Catra, and Bow as they pierce the dark storm clouds above them. The entire mountain range is dull and gray, except for the fairly close purple building that Adora can only assume is Dryl. The gravel presses into Adora’s feet through her shoes, poking and prodding

them painfully as she takes each step. She's so tired and they haven't even arrived yet. She can only hope that recruiting this Entrapta person isn't a hassle like Plumeria.

The thought of Plumeria clouds Adora's mind as she remembers the events of the weeks prior. She couldn't save anyone, she was barely a hero that day. The real hero was Perfuma. If she hadn't shown up the trio would probably be dead, and that would be all Adora's fault. Adora groans loudly, balling her hands up into fists so hard her fingernails dig into her skin. The uncomfortable feeling grounds her as she continues to walk, aggravated by the sudden turn in her already grim thoughts.

She still hasn't even told Catra about her past. They all have this idealized version of her in their heads and they have no idea she's been lying this entire time. She doesn't deserve them at all, trusting her implicitly over something she didn't choose. Something she doesn't deserve, because whoever She-Ra was in the past wasn't some freak like her. She's honestly surprised they haven't noticed how fake her attempt to make her voice more feminine is or how boxy and gross her, well, *everything* looks.

"You ok there, Adora?" Bow asks kindly. Adora admires him as much as she can, but sometimes she really doesn't want to talk about it and this is definitely one of those times.

"I'm fine, Bow." She shoots him a half-hearted grin, hoping he won't notice just how broken apart she feels inside at this moment.

Adora looks down at her feet, eyeing the battered and beaten up shoes she's been wearing forever as she walks. She doesn't think she's ever worn anything else than this dumb outfit. They offered her a jacket back in the Horde but she was quick to turn it down, sticking instead to the plain white shirt and combat pants typical of a Horde grunt.

It's possible that she hates She-Ra in one way or another for that reason. She's too flamboyant, too extravagant. She-Ra is a house party while Adora is the cops.

Adora is stirred from her thoughts as the trio approach the large purple building. A large metal door makes up the entrance to Dryl, tightly closed and secured by a keypad. No windows or decorations cover the outside at all. Entrapta must not be one for decor, she thinks.

Her hands find the edges of the door as she attempts to pry in open, succeeding only in tiring herself out instead. The door is large and made of steel, opening from the center like some kind of spaceship.

A flash of anger fills Adora's face and before she knows it her foot finds the door. A yell escapes her mouth as she kicks once, twice, to no real avail.

"Fuck!" She mutters. She must look so pathetic in front of Bow and Catra.

"Well, if brute force won't do it, let's try the keypad." Catra offers.

Bow nods, approaching the keypad and typing in some numbers. One set brings a loud buzz. An error sound. Another set: the same story. Bow makes several more tries, each more complex than the last, and none of them offer anything substantial.

The rage returns and Adora's face feels flushed. An idea crosses her mind, but before she can process it and make her decision her body moves, slamming the edge of her sword into the keypad. Electricity crosses the gap, sending a bolt of lightning through the sword and into Adora's body. Her adrenaline spikes as panic surrounds her like a growing darkness. She gasps, collapsing to the ground.

"ADORA!" Catra yells, coming to the blonde's side.

Adora groans. "I'm fine. Just a little shock. Nothing worse than Shadow Weaver." Bow and Catra don't respond, instead staring at Adora in horror. "What? Happens all the time."

"Your mother-" Catra uses her fingers to form air quotes around that last word. "Used electric magic on you-" She scoffs. "As- as punishment?"

"Yea? Doesn't that happen to most people?" Adora shrugs. "Your mom probably did that to you too."

Catra finds Bow's eyes, looking over to see him looking nearly as horrified as she does. "Adora, Angella doesn't use her magic to hurt people." Bow says matter-of-factly.

"Oh." Adora's face grows grim at this revelation, before twisting into one of horrified amusement. A nervous laugh escapes Adora's mouth as she turns around, pointing the sword towards the open door. "Let's go!"

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"What the hell happened here?" Glimmer mutters. The entire building is eerily quiet, save for the occasional loud whirring noise of a machine turning on or off. No one seems to be home and there are definitive signs of a struggle. Scratch marks line the doorways where they've been forced open by something with much more strength than even Scorpia could muster.

The pair wander through the maze-like halls. Glimmer is looking for an explanation, more than anything, to where exactly everyone is. Their mission was to capture Entrapta but the princess is nowhere to be found.

A loud sound breaks the quiet investigative stupor the pair are in as machine twice Scorpia's height barrels down the hall towards them with-

Fuck.

"Scorpia. Get out of the way." Glimmer commands. Scorpia doesn't bat an eye and jumps toward Glimmer, pulling the pair both to the side of the hall as the robot continues down it on its death parade.

Scorpia chuckles, a little anxiety tinting her tone. "Saw hands huh? Givin' me a run for my money here."

"We need to keep moving. The robots must have killed everyone." Glimmer says with a shudder.

"Killed? Gosh, you don't think they got out at all?" Scorpia asks.

"Scorpia, we have been here an hour and a half and have yet to see a single per-" Glimmer's sentence is cut off by the appearance of the boy with the arrows from Thaymore, moving around the corner with a trio of people. Glimmer taps Scorpia's arm and points. The boy hasn't noticed them yet, seemingly.

Scorpia nods and gets into a battle stance, causing Glimmer to make a noise of disapproval. "Through there." Glimmer mutters, pointing at a nearby doorway. The pair duck into it, waiting for the group to move past.

"Why didn't we try to get the jump on them when we had the chance?" Scorpia whispers, more loudly than Glimmer would like.

"Adora is here if he is. I don't want him warning her. Not yet." Glimmer nods, gesturing for Scorpia to follow her deeper into the depths of Dryl.

When the trio finally meet Entrapta, she's far more exuberant than Adora expects. She knows geniuses can be eccentric, but Entrapta might as well be the definition. The three watch as she tampers with a large door, half-talking to them and half-talking to herself.

"And so, I'm studying the ancient technology that the first ones employed to harness the magic of Etheria!" She says jovially.

"So, why are we standing around outside this door?" Catra raises her eyebrow.

"Oh! Right! Well, things are all a teensy bit deadly right now. I made my greatest discovery yet! But it made my bots freak out and now they want to kill me and probably you too." Adora doesn't like the grin Entrapta flashes as she finishes the sentence. "This door leads to my lab! I should be able to shut the robots down from here!"

"You have a *lab?* " Bow may as well be in heaven talking to the genius princess.

"I do and it's full of my scientific achievements!"

Adora wishes she understood what the purple haired princess was saying at all, but it sounds a lot like a bunch of made up words and sounds meant to confuse her. She tries her best not to groan, but a small huff escapes her lips.

Catra nudges the blonde slightly with her elbow. Adora sees from the corner of her vision a look in the magicat's eye, one of slight, steely concern.

"I'm fine, Catra." Adora mutters.

"Sure you don't need to sit down for a second? That was a nasty hit you took outside." Catra mutters back.

As much as Adora wants to give in and listen to Catra, she can't. They have a job here to do and Adora isn't going to let her personal problems invade their mission. She lifts her head up, trying to make sense of the sea of words she seems to be unleashing on Bow, who is nodding excitedly as the princess talks.

Bow's eyes sparkle at the very notion of getting to see Entrapta's inventions. He opens his mouth to respond to her rambling, but no words come out. Instead, the loud creak of sharp metal on metal scrapes down the hallway towards them.

Adora's head shoots up as her eyes focus on the source of the noise. A dozen foot tall robot is clambering down the hallway towards them at breakneck pace, sharp talons cutting into the metal walls as it shuffles and stomps its way about.

Almost reflexively the sword is in Adora's hands and raised to the sky. "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

Entrapta's eyes light up as the transformation occurs, replacing the six foot tall Adora with an even taller eight foot She-Ra.

But something's wrong. The electrical tingle returns to the back of Adora's neck as her body seems to move on its own. The sword makes incredibly quick work of the robot as it tears through metal plating like putty, each swing more aggressive than the last. A ringing forms in her ears as she struggles to regain control of her body. She can't regain the pilot's seat as the ringing increases to deafening levels. The edges of her vision start to blacken as voices begin to echo inside her head, louder and louder with each breath. They aren't intelligible, at least not that Adora hears, until one voice in particular screams a name.

MAAAAAARRRRRRAAAAAA! The voice shrieks, filled with agony.

Adora can't keep her head upright anymore as the blackness starts to take her, and she collapses.

Adora.

Adora!

"ADORA!"

Adora's eyes fly open as her whole body shudders in shock. A yelp escapes her lips as she bolts upright and comes nearly nose to nose with Catra.

"Oh thank god." Catra groans in relief. "I thought you were brain damaged. I didn't brain damage you did I?"

"Catra." Adora mutters. "Why are you on top of me?"

Catra's face turns red. "I was-" She grumbles. "I was worried about you ok?"

"You like me." Adora's face becomes smug. "Don't you?"

"No!" Catra practically yells. "No! Shut up!" With a loud groan Catra stands up, marching away from Adora.

Adora can see her surroundings more clearly now. She's in a lab. Entrapta's lab, probably. Dials and knobs and lights line the walls in spider web-like formations, all converging on a singular point in the center of the room. A chip of some kind, it looks like, glowing with bright green light and seeming to pierce into Adora's mind and calling to her.

As if she isn't in control of her body, Adora stands and steps over to the chip for a closer look. The tingling in her neck becomes almost electric as she reaches out her hand to touch the glowing green object.

"Adora, wait!" She hears Bow yell in the distance. He sounds light-years away as she closes her hand around the chip.

Electricity explodes through her body and Adora lets out a scream louder than she ever thought she could. Her spine feels as though its on fire as she's once again thrown on her back, the smell of burning flesh pungently filling the air as a mark forms where her right hand closed around the chip.

"Adora! Are you ok?" She hears both Bow and Catra say this intermittently as her head spins. Her eyes remain closed as the world seems to be turning and tossing upside down.

When she finally finds her land legs again, she isn't sure how much time has passed. Every part of her hurts. Her eyes open to the unsettlingly concerned faces of Bow and Catra, who gasp in unison as Adora blinks the fogginess out of her vision.

"Adora-" Bow starts. "Y-your eyes."

Her eyes? What about her eyes?

"Interesting! In addition to the chip's psychological effects, it also seems to have physical ones as well." Entrapta speaks into a tape recorder, eyeing Adora up and down.

"You *knew* about this? And you let us bring her *here?* " Catra's voice grows aggressive.

"I had my theories but I couldn't be sure. The tall one's sword is First One's tech so at some point it must have become infected as well." Entrapta says with a shrug.

"HOLD ON!" Adora yells. "What-" She swallows. "What's wrong with my eyes?"

Before anyone has the chance to respond, the sound of scraping metal echoes through the large chamber Entrapta calls her lab. Metal scraping against metal- No, something else, almost like a claw that grazes the labyrinth outside.

"Well, well, well." Chills run down Adora's spine at the growl that emerges from the dark hallway outside. "If it isn't Adora, out here playing princess with her new friends."

Glimmer's face emerges from the dark, followed by a large, white haired woman with a scorpion tail and an intimidating pair of claws.

"Glimmer." Adora mutters, groaning as she climbs to her feet. Jolts of electricity continue to run down her spine at intervals as she stands. "Force Captain Scorpia. Pleasure to meet you." She says, through gritted teeth.

Glimmer lets out an almost pained, sadistic laugh. "Thought you got rid of me, huh? Thought you didn't need me anymore?"

"Glimmer, no, I-" Adora starts.

"Save it. We're not here to chat." Glimmer's tone is cold, like needles of ice stabbing Adora in the back.

"What do you want?" Catra speaks next, doing her best to sound fierce in the face of this first encounter with her sister.

"What do *I* want?" Glimmer giggles. "I want her." She points a finger at Entrapta, who is not paying much attention at all, instead fiddling on her datapad.

"Tough shit. You can't have her." Catra glares.

"Oh, is the big bad kitty upset? What are you gonna do, scratch me?" Glimmer grins.

Adora feels rage overwhelm her body and before she knows what she's doing her sword swings towards Glimmer, stopping short of Glimmer's face. Protective anger fills her eyes as she stands between Catra and Glimmer, trying to keep the pair from attacking each other.

"Back off." Adora's face grows hot with anger as her eyes pierce into Glimmer's.

"Oh, Adora, protecting your little playmates?"

Catra finally loses it, extending her makeshift claws and throwing her left hand at Glimmer's face. Before contact arrives, Scorpia's large, armored arms come between them, blocking the blow and sending Catra tumbling back.

Bow readies an arrow, pointing it towards Scorpia as the five enter a standoff.

Adora is the first to move, swinging her sword at Scorpia, who's pincer reaches up and grabs hold of it, pulling Adora backward and slamming her against the wall.

Glimmer's lightning magic arcs out of her hands at Bow, who reflexively fires an arrow at her in response. Bow came prepared, and the arrow absorbs the current as it flies towards Glimmer's body. To Bow's surprise, Glimmer catches it mid air, letting out a *tsk tsk* as she fires another bolt of electricity.

"Bow!" Catra yells, pushing him out of the way and absorbing the brunt of the blow. She cries out in pain as shocks enter her body and connect to the ground. "That's no way to treat family." She grins as she leaps at Glimmer, catching her off guard.

"The fuck does that mean?" Glimmer takes a step backwards. "My family is dead."

Catra opens her mouth in response, but is met with a loud rumble. Before her sentence can leave her lips Entrapta's bots burst through the laboratory door, quickly overwhelming the five of them.

Adora doesn't know when it happens, but very quickly she finds herself fighting on the same side as Glimmer once again as a large bot ambushes the pair. Adora jumps to cut into it with the sword as Glimmer fires a bolt of electricity at it. The robot collapses as Adora steals a glance back at Glimmer.

The pink haired girl rolls her eyes. "Want a trophy?" She mutters. The sea of robots begins to slow steadily as Bow and Catra each take down two more.

"Glimmer, I-" Adora turns around, her face meeting Glimmer's fist. The blow leaves her dazed as the startled yelps of Catra and Bow fill her ears.

"Scorpia, grab the princess." Glimmer growls. Adora looks up to see the scorpion woman approaching Entrapta, who doesn't seem to understand or care.

"Entrapta!" Without warning Adora transforms into She-Ra, the hatred and anger she feels trickling into her veins like lava. She jumps up without a thought and breaks into a sprint. Her sword swings without further thought and meets the end of Scorpia's tail.

"You know," Scorpia scowls. "I don't think I like you much." She disarms Adora quickly, grabbing the sword and twisting it out of the blonde's hands. "You've got a real attitude, Adam."

The lava reaches Adora's heart, as her fists find Scorpia's chest. She knocks the wind out of the woman as she pushes her away, her glare cold as ice. "Don't ever fucking call me that."

"Adora!" Catra's voice calls out from across the room. She's toe to toe with Glimmer, who holds the very chip that turned She-Ra into a monster.

Adora reacts quickly, charging towards Glimmer. The witch meets her with an electric shock that could knock out a horse, causing Adora to crumple to the ground in pain.

"Well, it was nice seeing you again, Adora." Glimmer sneers. "But it's time to leave with what we came for."

Adora's eyes find Entrapta, being carried away in Scorpia's arms. The chip that she had been studying was firmly sitting in Glimmer's palm, glowing bright green.

Adora's form falls back to normal as she struggles to move her muscles. The pain of the electric shock is too much, overwhelming her senses. Tears flow down her face as she feels a hug close in from Catra.

"Why did you call her Adam?" Glimmer mutters as the duo trudge along the hallways of Dryl.

"Who?" Scorpia shoots a look back at Glimmer, clearly confused.

"Adora. You called her Adam. Why?"

"Isn't that what we called her back in the Horde?" Scorpia's question is innocent, clearly not understanding why Glimmer's tone seems to radiate venom.

"No. That's what *Shadow Weaver* calls her. But her name is Adora. Don't call her that." Glimmer tries her best to keep her tone even and uncaring, but she can tell she's failing as Scorpia sighs.

"You really cared about her, didn't you?"

"No. I hate her guts. I just want to stick it to Shadow Weaver." Glimmer grumbles. She hopes that her angry tone can mask the caring in her voice. A caring that she should purge from her heart. She looks down at the chip in her hand, its green glow lighting up the dim hallway rather brightly.

"What do you think it is?" Scorpia asks innocently.

"No idea. It seems dangerous, though. Adora didn't want us to get it. We can probably use it to bait Entrapta and nab her. This is just a little bonus for Hordak to get." Glimmer grins evilly.

"Bait her how?"

Glimmer enchants the chip with a spell, eyeing it slyly and looking up at Scorpia. "Touch it."

Scorpia reaches out a pincer and the chip responds with a large zap of electricity. "Ow!" Scorpia chuckles. "So we're gonna knock her out."

"Yep." Glimmer grins. "Just need to set the trap."

"Scans show they're still inside the building." Entrapta says in her cheery tone.

"Why? They have the chip? What more do they need?" Bow raises an eyebrow.

The floor of the lab is littered with Entrapta's papers, a result of their scuffle not long ago. Adora sits on the ground, the words spoken by Scorpia stinging and stabbing her through the heart. Her eyes are wide, the rage in her heart threatening to resurface when, suddenly, a moment of clarity arises.

"It's a trap." Adora climbs to her feet, Catra steadying her by her arm. "She doesn't want the chip."

"She wants-" Catra's eyes go wide. "She wants Entrapta."

"Why?" Bow's tone fills with alarm.

"Entrapta is a genius. No alien chip could match what that brain of hers could come up with." Adora shakes her head. "So we set a counter-trap."

Catra nods. "So wherever they set it, we send Entrapta in first, wait for their guard to be down, and jump."

"AH!" Entrapta yells, causing Bow to jump. "I've pinpointed the chip's location. It's in Dryl's kitchen, where I make tiny food!"

Catra nods. "Time to set our own trap."

The plan is simple: have Entrapta and Catra go looking for the chip inside Dryl's kitchen, at which point Glimmer and Scorpia will attempt to kidnap Entrapta. Adora and Bow then will sneak up behind them and attempt to restrain them.

Adora can only hope this works as she and Bow position themselves on either side of the large swinging kitchen doors. Bow readies an arrow, looking just as nervous as Adora feels while they wait.

Suddenly Adora hears yelling. Bow had provided a part of a sonic arrow to use as a signal and that sure doesn't sound like it. Something is wrong, both Adora and Bow know it as they quickly forced their way through the doors into the kitchen.

The sight that greets them is horrific, as Adora finds Catra twitching on the ground. Her sword quickly finds Glimmer's staff as the pair go head to head.

"So angry, Adora. What did I ever do to you?" Glimmer sneers, shooting a blast of magic at her that Adora deflects.

Adora counter-attacks with an overhead swing, bringing down on the hilt of the pink-haired girl's staff. "You've been trying to kill us, for starters!"

Glimmer cackles. "Only once or twice!" Another bolt of electricity fires out of the staff, this time zapping Adora in the arm.

"Adora!" Catra leaps up, throwing the chip towards the blonde. Adora reaches out to grab the chip, but before it reaches her hand Glimmer intercepts it.

"Thank you, Princess!" Glimmer whips toward Adora, smashing her in the face with the butt of her staff.

Adora's sword emanates a loud *clang* as her body crumples to the ground. She groans in pain, the world seeming to spin around and around as she struggles to regain her sense of direction.

She struggles to her feet, using the sword as leverage for a moment before Glimmer kicks it out from her grip.

"Get your hands off me you brute!" Catra growls. Adora looks up to see her struggling in Scorpia's grip, trying to slash at the scorpion woman's claw to no avail.

"C-catra." Adora groans. She looks around for Bow, who is trapped in the corner with Entrapta and disarmed. Her world spins as she struggles to crawl towards them, vomit threatening to spill from her guts at any moment as her stomach cries out for relief from the vertigo.

She catches Glimmer's eye, who is chuckling evilly. "You're pathetic." She says, leaning down and picking the sword up. "Looks like we made out like bandits!"

The world spins faster as Adora watches the pair leave, Catra in tow. Her sword is gone, and the chip is equally as lost. She

couldn't even control her powers because of that damned chip.

She lost.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much for reading! I promise the next chapter will be out much sooner!

Interlude

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Bow begin to lose hope as chances of rescuing Catra grow more and more slim as Adora learns about her predecessor. Glimmer starts to question Shadow Weaver's lies.

Chapter Notes

> As always the usual warnings apply!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hope! Hope! Wait for me!"

Hope turns her head, eyeing the familiar form of a woman not much shorter than she is. She's olive skinned, a long brown ponytail extending behind her back. Her grayish eyes and optimistic smile stare almost lovingly through Hope's stony gaze.

"Don't you have training to do, Mara?" Hope quips, rolling her eyes.

"Oh please, like you've ever consistently trained before." Mara pokes Hope in the arm. "Besides, I wanna see what you're up to!"

Hope averts her eyes, suddenly finding the ground much more interesting. "I'm not very interesting, Mara. Surely there's someone else who will interest you more."

"Oh, please, Miss Cold and Distant. You're my friend and that's why you're interesting."

Hope grits her teeth. "I don't have friends." Her walking speeds up in order to escape Mara.

"Hope! Wait!" Mara yells after her.

Adora's body is covered in sweat. The day has not been kind to her. First she loses Catra *and* Entrapta, and now She-Ra is deciding not to show up anymore, right when Adora actually wants her to.

The Whispering Woods spiral and twist all around her as she wanders. She knows that castle that she, Bow, and Catra had wandered into has to be around here still. If she could find it, maybe it could give her an answer.

Her wandering hasn't paid off yet, as the Woods don't seem to want her to find that Castle at all. Adora's ready to give up at this point, exhausted from the walking. Maybe she could just storm the Fright Zone as Adora.

Ha. Fat chance. She thinks. *You'd kill yourself trying.*

She almost turns around and heads back to Bright Moon when her eye catches something sparkling beyond the trees. She breathes a sigh of relief as she starts towards it, hoping its not another false alarm.

It isn't. The castle looks exactly the same as it did the day she arrived at Bright Moon. She approaches the large building, which, to her, would be very hard to miss in these woods. It pokes out through the top of the trees, a giant crystalline tower covered in moss and other plant life.

Adora walks towards the door. Like before it's sealed shut. Not a surprise to her.

"Eternia." She mutters, opening the door and stepping inside. The air inside feels different this time, almost cold and unforgiving. As if she's not welcome inside the large structure. Maybe she isn't. She isn't really sure.

She approaches the center atrium, which is surrounded by various states of decay. The place really is falling apart, especially after what she and Catra did to it. In fact, how did the door repair itself? Didn't Catra slice it apart?

"What is your query?" A voice speaks, causing Adora to yelp in fear. A hologram has appeared, beams of light assembling into the

shape of a woman. The woman is about Adora's height, maybe a little bit shorter. A long ponytail stretches down behind her head, which is adorned with a headpiece.

"She-Ra. Do you know her?" Adora asks gruffly. She's been around Catra too much.

"What is your query?" The hologram asks again, unwavering.

"I need to know how to get She-Ra back." Adora asks slowly, growing impatient.

"What is your query?" The woman asks one more time.

Adora yells in frustration. "A friend of mine has been kidnapped! I need help! I *am* She-Ra!"

"She-Ra not detected. What is your query?"

Adora groans, sitting down on the step that leads up to the platform and placing her face in her palms. She doesn't have time for this. Catra is in danger. Entrapta is in danger. Finally a thought occurs to her. Something she should have led with.

"Who are you?" Adora asks, plainly and without the previous frustration in her voice.

"I am the Magical Autonomous Real-time Assistant, otherwise known as MARA."

"Ok, Mara. Nice to meet you. How can you help me?" Adora asks, again trying to remain plain.

"I am designed to assist the one known as She-Ra in her mission to protect the interests of the First Ones." Mara replies.

"I am She-Ra. Can you give me some assistance?"

Mara turns red. "Access denied. She-Ra not detected." She returns to her previous white color.

Shit.

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*"I- I keep having these dreams. A sword- **my** sword sits in the trees, buried in the ground. It just- it just sits there, while white light bathes it from everywhere around it. The sword- it calls me. It's begging me to find it. I don't know what it means." Hope*

shakes her head. A hand reaches out and touches her on the thigh. Hope raises her head, meeting the gaze of her wife.

"We'll figure it out. I promise. We always do." Mara smiles at her. Hope is tempted to pull the woman in for a kiss right there. Hell, maybe she should.

"I just wish I knew what it meant." Hope stands up, straightening her long, flowy overcoat. She reaches a hand out to Mara, helping her stand as well.

"Well, I'm sure the mighty She-Ra will find the answer." Mara giggles. "My wife! The She-Ra!"

Hope smiles hesitantly.

Adora sits on the steps leading to the door of the Crystal Castle. She's not exactly disappointed with what she found. Hell, she might even have expected it. The First Ones haven't proven themselves very helpful to her at all. She doesn't have her sword, her powers, or even Catra.

She's completely alone. That's what scares her. If she had just been smarter and hadn't focused so much on what Scorpia had

said at Dryl, maybe she wouldn't have let them get Catra and her sword.

"Oh, Adora. Oblivious as ever." Glimmer had said as they paraded off with her friends. Adora hasn't even seen Bow since then. She assumes he's been moping about as much as she has.

Catra probably hates her guts anyways. Adora let her get captured. She let Glimmer get away with the chip and her sword. The only thing they managed to hang onto was Entrapta.

Worst of all, Adora doesn't even have She-Ra. She's lost the one thing she's good for even. Glimmer managed to take everything from her. The sword was her one good feature and its been stolen.

"If you are nothing without the sword deary, maybe you shouldn't have it!" An old lady's voice breaks through Adora's thoughts, nearly scaring the life out of her.

She yelps, jumping to her feet. "Who are you?!" She eyes the elderly woman up and down. The woman is no more than five feet tall, hunched over in a large robe like garment. Her hair is messy enough to rival Catra's. Her eyes seem to pierce Adora's shield through her very thick and round glasses.

The old woman laughs. "Razz is Razz. You know that dear. Now, come! We have pie to make, Hope!"

"H-Hope?" Adora mutters, following the woman away from the Crystal Castle.

"Yes! Hope! Have you forgotten your name?" The woman cackles as they leave the clearing surrounding the Castle, into the woods.

"N-no. My name isn't-" The old woman knocks Adora on the head with her cane before she can finish. "OW! What was that for?"

"You need to stop worrying so much about that Mara! She's a tough girl!"

Mara?

"W-wait. What does Mara have to do with anything?" Adora's confusion only worsens.

"Mara? Who said anything about Mara?" The old woman already seems to have forgotten.

"You did!" Adora says. The pair continue walking through the woods over fallen trees and twisting vines. "You said her name!"

"Nonsense, Adora. I said nothing of the sort." The pair come to a clearing, where a small house carved into the side of a large tree branch sits. Covering the doorway is a cloth of some sort.

"How do you know my name?" Adora follows the woman in.

"Razz knows many people's names. Never forgets them." Razz cackles. "Now, come Hope! Pie won't make itself!"

Adora groans under her breath. Who is this woman? How does she know her name? Who the hell is Hope?

The inside of Razz's abode is rather cramped, much more than Adora would prefer. In the corner is a pot sitting over some firewood and beyond that a large stone oven. Adora wonders how long Razz has been out here.

"She was much like you, my Hope." Razz says, taking a seat beside the pot of steaming water.

"But-" Adora barely gets the word out before she's interrupted by Razz, who hits Adora with her cane.

"No buts! You should be more like her! Hope never second guesses herself!" Razz cackles. "She was an incredible She-Ra!"

She-Ra?

"W-wait. Madame Razz, are you telling me there are more She-Ra's?" Adora asks shakily.

"No, no! Only one at a time, Hope! They protect Etheria! Now come! Pie is almost ready!"

A cold rage fills Hope's heart. Mara is gone, ripped away from her by the people she was sworn to protect. Her body feels heavy, like walking with cinder blocks attached to her feet. From the back of her chest comes a guttural scream of pure, unadulterated anguish. Her ship was the loneliest place in the universe now. Everywhere she looks Mara should be there.

Her fists find the console of the craft as the cold rage turns to hot fury. Once, twice, three times she slams her left fist against the electronics before switching to the other hand in a back and forth flurry. Blood dribbles down her knuckles, but Hope doesn't care. She wants to hurt. She wants to feel the pain.

The pain almost grounds her. It reminds her of what she's been through. It reminds her that trusting anyone is dangerous. What a joke it all was. She-Ra was never a protector, she was a weapon. A weapon that kills.

The cold rage returns to Hope's body. She feels like she's swallowed dry ice, the cold, uncaring feelings of her youth returning. Her mind finally finds a point, a singularity on which to focus until the day she dies. Mara won't die in vain, she decides, as she punches in the coordinates of a single planet.

Etheria.

Adora has seen very few pies in her life, maybe none at all, but this is the most amazing one she has ever seen. It's perfectly golden brown and glistening on top, with the most delicious smell of lemon filling her nose with its strong, tart scent.

Her stomach rumbles as she finally realizes how hungry she actually is. She hasn't eaten since days prior. Adora has been too busy worrying about Catra to bother. Her best friend has been kidnapped and she's been moping.

She groans pretty loudly, causing Razz to turn and eye her a second.

"Something wrong, Hope?" She chuckles.

"Who is Hope?" Adora asks again, still unsure of the woman's true identity. All she's gleaned from the increasingly confusing and frustrating interactions with Razz is that she has something to do with the AI in that First Ones fortress.

"In due time, Hope! She'll be the best of you!" Razz says.

"Who?" Adora blinks. "The best of who?"

"The best of the She-Ra! Now eat!" She wacks Adora with her cane.

Adora lets out a yelp. "Ok, ok." She grumbles, popping a piece of the pie into her mouth. Her eyes go wide as the intense flavor of apples washes over her tongue, sweet and sticky and delicious as it melts in her mouth. "Wow!" She says, surprised. "This is amazing!"

"Hope thought so too." Razz says sadly.

"Who was she?" Adora asks, more politely this time. She's afraid the sudden moment of clarity from Razz might pass before she gets her answer.

"The She-Ra of course!" Razz chuckles. "She was so fond of Mara. It's a shame what happened to her."

"What happened? Did she die? What about Mara?" Adora asks rapidly.

"Quiet, Hope! Eat up!" She says, the lucidity gone.

Adora sighs before chowing down on more of the pie. Answers would have to wait.

Bow paces the inside of his room, on the verge of a panic attack. He's worried sick about Catra, and almost equally as worried about Adora. He hasn't seen her in days and it's only served to mount his anxiety even more.

He eyes the arrows he's been developing. A special kind based on some of Entrapta's designs. He wonders if he can truly get them to work like they should. In theory they should be able to disable any magical item or power, but so far he hasn't been able to test them.

"Bow!" Adora's voice breaks through his fog, causing him to jump.

"Adora?! Where have you been?! I've been so worried!"

"No time!" She says. "Did you know there was another She-Ra before me?"

"Well, yeah. It's a legend for a reason." Bow chuckles. "Why?"

"I think I learned something about her from the old woman in the woods, but she keeps forgetting and the stupid robot lady in the temple won't tell me anything about her without my sword and-"

"Adora! Slow down!" Bow can hardly understand what she's rambling about. "Start at the beginning!"

Adora takes a deep breath.

"So this old lady-"

"Razz."

"Right. Razz. She knows your name and who you are but won't tell you how to get answers from the hologram in the castle?" Bow asks, slightly more incredulously than he would have liked.

"I don't think she knows how. I think she and this Hope person were just friends for a time. Hope might never have shown her MARA." Adora sighs.

"So, basically, you can't learn anything without the sword." Bow says blatantly.

"Pretty much." She groans, cupping her face in her hands. "I'm so screwed. How are we gonna rescue Catra without the sword?"

"We'll improvise on that. The princess alliance should be able to help us as long as we have a plan in mind. I'll talk to Perfuma today and get her onboard." Bow nods.

"Are you sure she'll want to? She's…scary." Adora says, hushing her voice.

"The Alliance's commander is being held hostage. I have a feeling she's gonna get involved." Bow chuckles.

Adora nods. It'll have to do. Perfuma, Bow, Adora, and Entrapta will have to take matters into their own hands.

"Absolutely not. We are not going to risk any more lives until we know exactly what the Horde wants." Angella says, pursing her lips.

"Your majesty. If we wait we don't know what kind of things they might do to Catra! The Horde will stoop to any level to get what it wants and what it wants is-" Adora gulps. "-is me."

"You are not sacrificing yourself for the sake of my daughter, Adora. Catra is a capable warrior, she will survive there until a rescue party is properly assembled." Angella rubs her temple, clearly exhausted.

"No one knows the Horde like I do, ma'am."

"No. That is final." With that, Juliet swiftly escorts Adora out of the throne room.

"So, this is the child Micah was so desperate to protect." Fear rolls down Catra's spine as the chilling voice seemed to resonate through her. "What a little mongrel. Hardly worth my time."

Fear turns to rage, causing Catra to look up at the figure. She's close to seven feet tall, masked, and pacing- no, *gliding* across the floor. Catra lets out a cocky, aggressive laugh. "Shadow Weaver, I presume. I hope my father kicked your ass before he died."

The remark earns a strike in the face from the witch, the pain of which seeks to only make Catra's resolve stronger as Shadow Weaver adopts an even colder tone. "Your father? Only Micah would adopt a disgusting rat like you." If the woman is trying to intimidate Catra, she isn't impressed. The only thing stopping her from attacking Weaver right now is the chains holding her to the wall. They had taken her claws when they threw her in here, naturally, and she has no room to move her arms in the chains.

Blood trickles down Catra's forehead. "Go to hell." She spits through gritted teeth. Suddenly electrical shocks course through her body, pain reaching beyond her threshold and threatening to black her out. Screams make their way from her vocal cords unwillingly, threatening to tear a hole in her throat as the lightning refuses to cease.

Outside the door, Glimmer listens carefully as Shadow Weaver tortures Catra. She wants answers. The princess mentioned her parents being alive. A lie for sure, but she wanted to know what she knew of Bright Moon.

She teleports as soon as she's sure Shadow Weaver has glided out of the room, spotting Catra chained to the wall. Her fur smokes

slightly as blood drips from her mouth and forehead. She can't help but chuckle coldly at the sight, causing Catra's head to shoot up.

"You look like shit." Glimmer laughs.

"What do you want?" Catra mutters. Her voice comes out in a low, raspy tone, marred by the pained screaming of the previous minutes.

"Well, now, Princess. Don't be so happy to see me." Glimmer's tone drops. "I want answers."

"Answers to what? Your math homework, sprout?" Catra laughed, hoarse and dry.

"My- what?" Glimmer blinked, causing Catra to laugh again. She shook her head, frustration bubbling to the surface as she glared at Catra. "Shut up. You said my parents were alive. Why did you say that? Who are you?"

Catra blinks, seeming to eye Glimmer up and down, before clearing her throat. "Princess Catra of Bright Moon, at your service." She shoots Glimmer a smirk. "Though that's partly not true, just one is."

"What do you know about my parents?" Glimmer can't gauge Catra's thoughts, she's hiding behind a steely facade of non-concern.

"Your father was an incredible sorcerer. Most powerful I ever knew. Your mom is a steely, calculating monarch who cares but doesn't show it enough. Your sister is a hot, badass commander of the rebellion." Catra chuckles.

"Sister? Shadow Weaver never said anything about a sister." Glimmer slicks her hair back a little, processing. Was Catra telling the truth?

"Well she will be, once I kick the shit out of her."

Glimmer's eyes find Catra's, a smirk forming across the feline warrior's lips as the shock of the statement hits her at her core. Surprise turns to rage with a fast, sharp swiftness. "Liar. I don't have a sister. You're just trying to get under my skin."

"Believe what you want, Sparkles, but just ask Weaver." Catra coughs. "She'll tell you everything you want to know. Oh look, here she comes now!"

Glimmer's hair stands up on end, causing her to look around. Catra snorts at the sight. "Made you look!"

"Fuck you." Glimmer growls.

"Is that any way to treat your darling older sister?"

"You are *not* my sister." Glimmer turns and stomps away.

"Are you sure about this, Adora?" Bow says, his tone concerned as usual.

"Never been more sure of anything, Bow. If Angella won't help, we're gonna have to take matters into our own hands." Adora's grip tightens around her staff.

"You seem sure. More sure than I've seen you probably ever." Bow says as they run along, the woods whipping past them.

"I have to do something. We can't -" Her sentence is cut short by the appearance of Perfuma from across the way.

"Where are you going?" Perfuma says, her tone less sweet than usual.

"We're gonna get Catra back. Right Bow?" Adora groans as Bow doesn't answer, opting to look at the ground.

"By yourself? That's suicide." Perfuma shakes her head. "I'm coming with you."

Adora blinks. "You are?"

"We are!" Entrapta's shrill voice echoes out from behind Perfuma. Mermista, Princess of Salineas also steps out, looking bored as ever.

"Yeah, so, we didn't join the Princess Alliance just to have our leader, you know, kidnapped and killed." She rolls her eyes.

Adora feels tears build in her eyes. "Thanks, you guys. Let's go get Catra back."

Mermista groans.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much again to @SpillTheKatea for betaing! I'm actually working on the next three chapters (whew!) right now! So all of season one of Sister's will hopefully be completed before year's end!

The Fright Zone

Chapter Summary

Adora begins her crusade to rescue Catra, while Glimmer begins to question her past.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hello? Hope? Your wife… there's been an accident." Hope's breath hitches at the words, as she replays the message again and again. Mara's been gone almost a year now and she doesn't find much light in anything anymore. The message only serves to remind her of the pain she felt that day.

So Hope plays and replays the message, looking for some way she could have saved her wife. The others have noticed her personality shifting. The happy, content Hope has been replaced with a cold, ruthless machine akin to herself years ago. Nothing makes her happy anymore, the only thing that helps is distracting herself with her duties as She-Ra.

Her life will never be the same, she knows that much.

Tears roll down her cheeks as another angry, visceral scream escapes her vocal cords without her consent. Life without Mara just wasn't living at all.

Catra eyes the walls of her cell carefully. If she's to attempt a breakout, she needs a weapon. Right now she was clawless and chained to the corner. Helplessness, hopelessness building up inside her which she forces down to keep herself sane. She keeps looking, scanning the decrepit walls outside her cell until she spots it: Adora's sword, hanging on the wall next to the doorway leaving the prison.

She groans, knowing it won't be easy to get to. She has to first break off her chains, then out of the cell before she can reach it. This wasn't going to be easy. With a huff she reaches back and pulls with all her might against the chains, the feeling of the cold metal pressing through her fur and into her flesh over and over again.

Before long, or maybe much much later, Catra's wrists ached as she continued to yank the chains away from the wall. Her fur stained with her blood as the chains ripped into her skin through it. Strands and clumps of hair lay all around her as she continues to pull desperately, her wrists rubbed raw from the pulling.

"You'll never get out of those." A voice interrupts. Catra lifts her gaze to see Glimmer staring at her with a raised eyebrow.

"Well, hello again, dear sister." Catra's voice is hoarse, dry from having not drank anything in hours. "Come to ask me more about our parents?"

" *My* parents are dead." Glimmer maintains. "Shadow Weaver found me and took me in. That's all."

"You know she's evil, so why keep believing her on this? Can't fathom that she would lie to you?" Catra snarls.

"I-" Glimmer hesitates. "She wouldn't. I'm her star pupil."

"And maybe she wants to keep you that way. Keep you in line." Catra chuckles.

"Shut up." Glimmer growls, turning away from Catra. "You don't know me. Know us. Stop pretending you do." With that, she marches out of the room, leaving Catra to begin pulling at her chains once more.

Adora spies the familiar smog spilling out from the edge of the Fright Zone, indicating the rescue party was almost there. They would have to do this fast if they wanted to get out with their lives, Catra included.

A drainage pipe marks the actual start of Horde territory, leading through a hill that houses a building at its summit. A large concrete wall lines the bottom of the hill, the only way through

being into the drainage pipe. This isn't going to be easy or pleasant, Adora thinks.

"Mermista-"

"No! I am not swimming through the drainage pipe!" Mermista groans in response.

"Do you see another way through?" Bow asks, uncharacteristically forceful.

Mermista groans again. "Why did I come on this stupid mission?"

"Because we want to save our friend!" Perfuma pipes up, furrowing her brow.

"Catra's the only pleasant one of you people." Mermista sighs, walking towards the pipe. "What exactly do you want me to do when I'm inside?"

"See if you can't slip into the prison block and free Catra. The rest of us will split up and keep them distracted." Adora grins, earning several approving nods from the group as she gestures to follow her.

"UGH. This is SO GROSS." Mermista moans as she wades through Horde sewage. It was like swimming in thick paste and it smelled even worse than it felt.

Light fades from the tunnel as Mermista wades deeper inside, no lights to give her any sort of compass as she passes through. An oversight, she thinks, on Adora's part, but one she could get around by feeling the source of the current as she swam.

Darkness fully envelopes her, leaving her only to her other four senses. The sounds of rushing water get louder as she nears the source of the pipe. She is *definitely* going to need a bath when she gets home.

Suddenly she's stopped by the force of a wall, no, a grate at the end. She can see light just barely spilling out towards what she thinks is the end of the tunnel. Her hands find the edges of the grate, rocking it back and forth in a futile attempt to knock it loose. After a few more attempts, Mermista's vision is violated by incredibly bright light.

Her eyes struggle to adjust as she squints, trying to see the source. Purple hair spills down around white overalls in her vision as it begins to adjust to the sudden, overpowering white light.

"Entrapta?" Mermista groans.

"Yep!" Entrapta's voice jovially calls back. She uses her hair to climb along the ceiling, avoiding the water altogether.

"Why are you here?"

"Well, Adora was worried about sending you alone and wanted someone to follow you in case you got into trouble. She already paired up the others so the obvious choice was me!" Entrapta grins.

"Well, do you have anything that can cut open this metal hatch thing?" Mermista rolls her eyes, secretly a little thankful that Adora was looking out for her.

"Of course!" Entrapta lowers her face mask, pulling a torch from her overalls and lighting it. Without much work, she cuts the grate enough to where Mermista can pull it right off.

"Ok. I think we're almost there. Follow me and stay quiet." Mermista gestures.

Glimmer looks around hesitantly. Was she really going to do this? Break the rules and sneak into the archive?

Who was she kidding, of course she was. She places her hand on the id scanner. Her Force Captain ID wouldn't open it, but she's known Shadow Weaver's override code since she was a child.

The door opens to a large and dark room. The air is cold, chilly enough to even make Glimmer shiver a little as she walks. Large servers twice her height line up in aisles, glowing green as they take and store data of all kinds. Security camera footage, mission records, death logs, it was all here.

She looks around for any identifying information. She spies a large letter B on the side of one of the units, guessing this must mean the rows are sorted by subject. She shuffles quickly past B and C, towards row G. If her information was anywhere it would be there, right?

She walks along the row, eyeing each unit as she walks. She spies one of them with a screen attached, a navigation keyboard below it for accessing the row's information. Bingo. Her hands fly across the keys as she types her own name, desperate to prove to that princess that her parents were dead. Before long her face pops up on screen.

Glimmer, Force Captain.

DOA Moon 5, Day 24

Status: Alive

Her eyes scan the contents, looking for the details of her arrival. Before long she finds it locked behind another passkey terminal. Good thing she knows Shadow Weaver's codes.

Lord Hordak's Notes as Follows:

Abducted by Force Commander Shadow Weaver as retaliation for the Horde's loss at the Battle of Half-Moon. Shadow Weaver's motives are ulterior, but the girl is Bright Moon's princess and an asset to our cause.

The girl is more powerful than even I understand. Events surrounding her abduction must be kept secret in order to keep her in line.

Glimmer's hands shake a little as tears stream down her cheeks. Of course she knew Shadow Weaver had been lying, but to admit that that half-wit princess was right? Horror turns to rage as black lightning arcs in her hands. A solid punch and the server is destroyed.

Black smoke pours out, low to the ground. She really did a number on that server. No, this was different. This was *her.*

Glimmer spins around, spying the familiar mask of Shadow Weaver staring down at her. "Why?" She spits.

"You were meant to inherit the Horde. A perfect soldier and leader. This would only distract you." Electricity crackles from Shadow Weaver's hands as it jolts towards Glimmer.

Glimmer jumps to the right, causing the bolt of lightning to arc into another server console. The smell of smoke fills her nostrils as flames begin to crackle within the unit. She has to think fast. Shadow Weaver is good, but she's lighter and faster.

She rolls past Shadow Weaver, kicking her leg out as she goes. It makes contact with the taller woman's knee, causing her to cry out in pain as Glimmer hops up behind her and sends another bolt of electricity right into her back. Shadow Weaver crumbles to her knees.

"You miserable little runt! I saved you from the clutches of those princesses and this is how you repay me?" She snarls.

"Oh, so I'm a runt now? I thought I was the best of you." Glimmer growled. She has no way out of this if she can't eliminate Shadow Weaver.

"Shadow Weaver!" A gruff, familiar voice fills the room. "Forces have spotted the princesses at the East gate!"

Shadow Weaver sighs, standing up. "We are *not* done here, child."

Luck was on Glimmer's side.

Adora's growing impatient. Mermista and Entrapta still haven't returned and she, Bow, and Perfuma are growing more and more outnumbered. There's only so much she can do without her sword, leaving most of the heavy lifting to Perfuma, who has been taking out soldiers left, right, and center with her roots.

A familiar boot slams into Adora's abdomen, stunning her as she falls to a knee. Her eyes find her assailant's, who looks down at Adora with a mix of anger and sadness.

"Lonnie." Adora groans, finding her footing. "We don't have to do this."

"Oh, please, Adam. You never cared about us. You were just looking for the first excuse out." Lonnie growls back, sending a kick towards Adora's leg.

Adora sidesteps the kick, using the opening to send her knee crashing into Lonnie's waist. "Don't call me that." She mutters as Lonnie stumbles with a groan.

"You are such a loser." Lonnie throws another punch, this time connecting with Adora's face. Adora staggers back, anger beginning to boil up inside of her. "What happened to your eyes? Just another stupid princess thing, huh Adam?"

Rage overflows as Adora begins throwing kicks and punches, relentlessly pummeling her foe as a scream escapes her lungs.

"Adora!" Bow and Perfuma simultaneously grab her by the arms, preventing her from throwing anymore punches as they drag her away from Lonnie.

"LET ME AT HER. I'LL SHOW HER WHO'S A LOSER!" Adora screams, struggling to escape Bow's strong grip. A cold presence begins to wash over her, sending a chill down to her bones. Her eyes pan over in fear, finding the familiar shape of Shadow Weaver standing at the front of the crowd of soldiers.

"Well, well, Adam. Seems you're still as insolent as ever." Shadow Weaver says coldly. "The only thing you were ever good for was that secret power trapped inside you, one that you waste on these useless princesses."

Bow and Perfuma pull Adora back away from Shadow Weaver, who raises a hand. A single bolt of magic finds its way out of the woman's palm and into Adora's chest, sending her into darkness.

"You look miserable."

Catra raises her head to see the face of Glimmer once more. She smirks, blood trickling down her wrists as she attempts a lunge.

Glimmer cackles. "You really thought that was going to work?"

"Kinda hoped it might." Catra chuckles. "Come to taunt me more?"

"No." Glimmer's face falls to one of anger. "Is- is our mother really alive?"

The question catches Catra off guard. "Y-yeah. Yeah, she is." What was this all about?

"She lied to me. She *lied* . For nineteen years." Glimmer growls. Catra watches her gaze fall on the sword in the corner. Glimmer steps over to it, picking it up and tossing it inside the cell. "Just make sure she loses."

Catra picks it up, slicing her chains off and looking up at Glimmer. "Come with me. We can all live together at Bright Moon. We can stop the Horde side by side."

"No. I may be letting you go, but consider this mercy." Glimmer turns and briskly stomps out.

Catra picks the sword up in her left hand, cuffs still wrapped around her wrists as she raises it and begins to hack away at the bars.

Mermista's eyes struggle to adjust in the dim lighting of the Fright Zone's halls. Rust lined the edges of every panel of steel that made up the walls. The place really seemed more run down than Adora ever mentioned, but they were still giving the Alliance a run for its money.

She looks around for any sort of sign leading to a prison block. Not much luck to be had as most of the signs just listed where they *were* , not where they were going.

"Fascinating!" Entrapta squeals. "Look at all this technology! This place is amazing!"

"Yeah, well, let's try not to compliment the enemy too much on the decor." Mermista rolls her eyes as the duo take a left down yet another corridor. A door lies at the end, tightly shut by a pneumatic lock. Or, that's at least what Entrapta said it was.

Entrapta quickly hopped over to the keypad beside the door, punching in numbers with the tendrils of her hair faster than Mermista could register. "I'll have this open in a jiffy!"

Like that, the door whooshed open, revealing not a prison block, but an armory. Mermista almost groans, but realizes that Adora's giant princess sword might be in here. She puts a finger over her lips to signal Entrapta to be quiet, then gestures inside.

What awaited them within was a whole lot of guns. More guns than Mermista thinks she's ever seen in one place. Her eyes dart around, looking for any weaponry out of place. A sword would stick out like a sore thumb in here. She walks towards the back of the room where a set of lockers stands, padlocked.

She clicks her tongue at Entrapta. "Hey, science princess." She says quietly. "Cut that open with your blowtorch."

Entrapta nods, quickly slicing through the edge of the padlock. Mermista swings the door open, revealing not Adora's sword, but a pair of clawed gloves.

"These are Catra's." Mermista picks them up, sliding them on her hands. With a quick flick of the wrist she extends them.

"Fascinating! I would love to meet whoever designed these!" Entrapta makes an attempt to pull them off Mermista's hands, but the water princess pulls them away.

"No time. Let's go." She points a now clawed finger towards two Horde soldiers running their way.

The first lunges towards Entrapta, who quickly disarms him with her hair before picking him up and slamming him into the ground.

The second makes a pass at Mermista with his baton, which the water princess quickly dodges. She scratches at the soldier's arm, ripping through his armor and cutting through his flesh.

The soldier cries out in pain, dropping the baton and clutching his left arm as the pair make their getaway. Mermista definitely did not realize how much damage these claws could really do.

The pair come back to a crossing, this time going straight across into darkness.

Catra has never been in the Fright Zone. The halls seem to twist and turn around her as the crackling sounds of explosions ring outside. That must have been why there were no soldiers in the prison block. Something was going on above.

Her hand tightens around the sword as she reaches an open doorway. Beyond it was a bridge with a large woman standing on it, one who Catra recognized as Force Captain Scorpia.

"We don't have to do this. You can just let me go and we can both forget about this." Catra calls.

"You'd like that wouldn't you, Princess?" Scorpia chuckles with a bit of an edge behind it.

The two remain at a standstill until Catra decides to make the first move. She leaps onto the railing, running at Scorpia at top speed.

Scorpia responds by swiping her claw out at Catra, catching her in the arm and sending her flying off the railing and onto the bridge behind her. Catra rolls, able to retain her footing, as she pops back up and lands a blow squarely on Scorpia’s arm.

The larger woman cries out in pain, clutching her wound for a second before swiping at Catra with her good arm. Catra catches it with the edge of the sword, becoming locked in a standstill with Scorpia for control. Scorpia’s gaze grows harder as she pulls the sword away, taking Catra with it. A moment of panic overcomes Catra as she flies through the air once more, time seeming to slow around her.

She eyes Scorpia’s bad arm, rolling in midair and landing a hard kick into the wound she created with the sword. Scorpia cries out once more, falling to her knees as Catra lands, left hand still tightly gripping the Sword of Protection.

“It’s over, Scorpia.” Catra heaves, out of breath.

“Just get out of here. I won’t tell anyone I saw you.” Scorpia’s voice is somber, defeated.

Without much time to waste, Catra makes a run for the door.

Her well executed escape is sorely interrupted as she slams right into Mermista, who yelps as the pair both fall to the ground. Catra has to think fast before Scorpia gets up. She hops up, whirling around and slamming the sword into the door controls, disabling it. Without time to waste she can hear Scorpia begin to slam her claws against it.

She breathes a sigh of relief, reaching a hand down towards Mermista. Mermista rolls her eyes and takes it, climbing to her feet.

"What are you doing here?" Catra asks.

"We're, like, here to rescue you, dummy." Mermista smirks.

"I thought no one would come, honestly. There are more important things to do in Bright Moon."

"You're the literal leader of the whole operation, Catra, I'm pretty sure you're important." Mermista rolls her eyes affectionately.

"Well, in any case, thank you." Catra eyes the woman's hands, noticing her claws. "How have they been treating you?"

"These things can do some damage, girl. I had no idea you were so dangerous." Mermista chuckles.

"Was it just you then? How'd you make it this far all by yourself?" Catra looks around for anyone else, to no avail.

"What do you-" Mermista suddenly looks around, groaning. "Oh, come *on* Entrapta!"

"Well she couldn't have gotten far, let's go." Catra points the sword towards the far hall.

"Adam."

Adora's eyes fly open, looking around for intruders. She's dangling by her arms, Perfuma and Bow in the same position and unconcious mere feet away from her. Shadow Weaver stands in front of her, her cold hands wringing as her mask stares into Adora's soul.

"That's not my name." Adora growls. Her eyes dart to her chains, which were thicker than she imagined and wouldn't budge no matter how much she strained.

"I don't care what fantasy name you've given yourself. You are Adam and you will always be Adam." Shadow Weaver chuckles twistedly.

"If I get out of these chains I swear-" Adora's sentence is cut off by a blast of magic, hitting her square in the face.

"You won't be going anywhere unless I say so." Shadow Weaver snaps her fingers, causing Adora's head to become very fuzzy.

"Wha-" Adora looks up, losing track of her thoughts as her memory begins to escape her.

"Ugh. How does she cover so much ground?" Mermista groans, earning a snicker from Catra.

"It's the hair. They're like really long legs." Catra chuckles. The pair hadn't had much luck through most of the other prison cells, wondering what exactly she had gotten distracted by.

The pair come to a much larger door with a keypad attached. Cracked open, the two could hear Entrapta giggling inside. Catra raises an eyebrow, gesturing for Mermista to peek inside with her.

Inside the chamber was a large stone, not unlike the Moonstone that gave her mother her powers. It glows with a reddish-black energy, sparking and crackling electricity from point to point on its surface. The electricity reminds Catra of the bolts of lightning Glimmer emitted from her hands, wondering if this was where she got her power from.

Catra enters slowly, eyeing Entrapta scanning all over the large gemstone, carefree and unaware of the dangers. Catra tries to be careful, but Mermista dashes that plan almoat immediately.

"ENTRAPTA!" Mermista shouts, more loudly than usual for her standards. "What the hell were you thinking? You could have gotten captured! Or killed!" Showing concern for anyone at all is rare for Mermista, and seeing it gives Catra a new respect for her.

"I detected a *massive* energy source and I just had to check it out! For science!" Entrapta grins, earning a groan from Mermista.

"Listen, we can chat later, but we need to go before we get caught, then-" A scream breaks off her sentence, echoing out from somewhere nearby. It was eerily familiar, deep and masculine but with traces of an edge Catra recognizes. Almost as if-

Adora.

"We need to go, now." Catra says with urgency. Mermista is clearly taken aback by the shift in tone, but when she meets Catra's eyes she just nods.

Catra takes off running down the hall, Mermista and Entrapta in tow. Another scream echoes through the halls, louder this time. It was a scream of pain, one that Catra would have recognized all too well if it weren't for the deeper tone.

It echoes, closer and closer, until Mermista grabs Catra by the shoulder. "It's through there." She gestures down a hallway to her right. "Who is that anyway? It doesn't sound like Bow."

"It's Adora." Catra says grimly as they run, barreling down the hallway.

"Adora? Adora doesn't scream like that." Mermista says inquisitively.

"It's definitely her. I don't know why, but it's her."

The pair reach the end of the hall. A closed doorway lies to Catra's left, through which she can hear the screams and the cold, taunting voice of Shadow Weaver.

"Soon you'll see the error of your ways, Adam." Weaver taunts. Adora was definitely through there, and maybe her other friends might be too.

"No, please! Why are you doing this, Shadow Weaver?" That voice definitely belonged to Adora, though it was deep and masculine compared to her regular voice. A product of Adora's past, more than likely. Why was she using it?

Catra decides she can't listen to this much more, slamming the butt of the sword into the door over and over again, hoping to break it down. Mermista taps her on the shoulder and points at the claws she wore on her hands.

Catra nods, pointing her head at the door. With two quick slashes Mermista has it open, revealing the figures inside. Adora hangs from a set of thick steel chains, Bow and Perfuma flanking her. They're both unconscious, leaving Adora to deal with Shadow Weaver, who is mere feet away from her.

The quick slices didn't come without some noise though, as Shadow Weaver's head turns to look directly at the pair. Catra feels like her bones are growing cold just looking at the woman, almost as if the woman's gaze tortures her from across the room. A flicker of anger at her treatment of Adora flashes across her face, rage bubbling up inside like a volcano ready to erupt.

"You keep your *fucking* hands off her." Catra growls, preparing to swing the sword at the woman. Shadow Weaver emits a bolt of lightning before the sword reaches its target, forcing Catra to jump out of its way.

Mermista launches herself at Shadow Weaver instead, getting a good slash at the woman's cape off. The assault serves as enough distraction for Catra to bring the sword down on Weaver's mask, shattering part of it and knocking her to the floor.

The woman screams in agony. "You little *mongrel* ." She growls through gritted teeth.

"Entrapta, cut their chains off. We're leaving." Catra stares down at Shadow Weaver, sword pointed in her face.

"If you were smart, *Catra* , you'd have killed me already." The woman spits.

"That's not how we do things in Bright Moon, lady. Maybe you, but not us." Catra rolls her eyes, turning her head to see Mermista and Adora with Bow and Perfuma over their shoulders.

"We're leaving. Come on." Catra gestures to the rest of the group to follow her.

Adora takes point in a surprising move for her. Standing at the front of the group, with Bow over her shoulder, she didn't say a word as she led the group through the twisting and turning halls of the Fright Zone.

"Where are we going?" Catra asks, a bit worried that her friend hasn't uttered a single word.

"Ventilation system. You'll be able to leave through there without causing too much of a scene." Adora says, her voice still deep and rough.

"What about you, Adora?" Catra raises an eyebrow.

"Why do you keep calling me that?" Adora shakes her head. "I could be imprisoned, or worse: sent to Beast Island, for helping you escape."

"You aren't part of the Horde anymore! Did that crazy woman mess with your mind?"

"What are you talking about?" Adora stops.

"You haven't been part of the Horde for almost six months. Here," Catra puts the sword in Adora's free hand. "This is yours."

"I've never owned a sword." Adora looks down at it, swinging it a few times. "Are you sure you have the right guy?"

" *Girl.* And yeah, I'm sure." Catra chuckles lightly. "Just look at what Shadow Weaver did to you. She tortured you. You can't stay."

Adora opens her mouth to say something, before sighing. She nods, tilting her head towards the ventilation shaft. The door is locked by a keypad with a five-digit code. Catra needs not say anything to Entrapta before she hops over, beginning to work at cracking the code. Catra supposes they could try to cut the door with her claws, but the door looked to be more than six inches of carbon plated steel, which would only serve to destroy them.

"I'll have this open in a moment." Entrapta says, using her hair to rapidly punch in numbers. A loud and blaring alarm sounds, causing Catra to shoot Entrapta an angry look. "It wasn't me! That couldn't have been triggered from here."

"The prisoner has escaped. I repeat, the prisoner has escaped."

Ah, that's what it was.

"Faster Entrapta, we don't have much time now." Catra turns to Adora and the group. "As soon as this door opens you run as fast as you can, understood?"

Entrapta shouts happily as the door slides open, turning to Catra. "We won't have much time. The ventilation system will try to purge us as soon as we enter."

Catra nods. "Everyone, RUN!"

The group takes off down the shaft, Catra running faster than she thinks she's ever run before. Sweat stains her fur as the fight or flight response kicks in full gear, her adrenaline fueling her to run faster and faster, the rest of the group in tow.

The door is close now, only about ten feet away, Catra and Mermista being the first to cross the threshold, followed by Adora. A loud yelp echoes from inside the chamber and Catra turns back to see Entrapta with a cable wrapped around her leg. Catra steps forward to help her, but the door snaps shut before she can get there.

A loud alarm followed by a whooshing sound emanates from the shaft, signaling that gas is being poured inside.

Catra feels her heart being ripped from her chest as the weight of what just happened presses fully on her. Entrapta is dead. Entrapta is *dead.* Entrapta, her friend, is dead.

A cry of anguish rips from Catra's throat as her fists slam against the closed door.

"IT SHOULD HAVE BEEN ME!" Catra yells. "ME!!"

She sinks to her knees, gravity taking hold of her as she refuses to move any more. A pair of muscular arms grabs her, picking her up in a bridal carry. Catra's eyes find the carrier's, who's red eyes and steely glare she recognizes all too well as Adora. Before long, exhaustion overtakes her, and she passes out.

Catra opens one eye hesitantly, recognizing the inside of the Bright Moon infirmary. A silent sigh of relief overcomes her. She's home, at least. No more prison cell, no more dead sisters.

"Well, ma'am" A voice says. "You've completely lost your memories of the last few years, based on testing."

"Why does everyone keep calling me ma'am?" The still masculine voice of Adora questions.

"Well, because up until you left for the Fright Zone, you presented as one." The nurse says gently. "Would you rather I not call you that?"

"N-no. It's not that, it's just-" Adora coughs. "A lot to take in."

"Well, think about it for a while. If you change your mind, just let us know." The nurse chuckles, walking over to Catra's bed. "Ah! You're awake!" She says, grinning down at Catra. "Good! How do you feel?"

"Like someone hit me over the head with a brick." Catra chuckles. "But I'll live." She sits up, struggling to move her body. Her wrists ached from the chains, her head was splitting open, and she must have inhaled something because she has a dreadful cough.

"Take it easy, miss." The voice of Adora next to her bed comes, gently helping her sit up against the headboard of the bed. "You had a nasty fall outside the Fright Zone."

"Adora." Catra chuckles. "You really don't remember anything, huh?"

"That's what they tell me, ma'am. Apparently I've been a resident of Bright Moon for…six months?" Adora smiles. "Not to mention the other three years I've lost."

"We'll get it back. I promise." Catra pulls Adora into a hug. "Though, I do want to ask, have you looked in a mirror lately? You don't seem to be remembering some really important details about yourself."

"I haven't yet. I imagine I'm in for quite a shock." She laughs, her usual dorky laugh emitting in a deeper cackle. "I definitely don't remember having such wide hips."

"Oh you have more than that." Catra retorts.

Did I just…flirt with her?

Adora giggles, her smile bringing a sort of warmth to Catra's heart. It was really good to just talk like this again. Catra had only been held captive a few days but they felt like weeks. Weeks since she'd seen Bow or Adora, her best friends. The 'Best Friends Squad' as he so dorkily put it.

There's still work to be done, but for now, all Catra can do is rest. "I'm gonna take a nap now, try to get some strength back for the meetings this afternoon. Be ready for an earful from my mom for risking your lives like you did."

"Your mom?" Adora tilts her head.

"The queen. Lady with the wings. Just watch out." Catra grins.

Adora grins back. "Can do."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks to RinniiArt for betaing this one! I'm already working on the next two chapters so the wait shouldn't be too long for them!

To Wish Impossible Things

Chapter Summary

> Princess Prom is in full swing and friends and enemies alike will clash

Chapter Notes

> Content warning for suicidal ideation and unintentional self-harm

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Ma'am, the Horde is inching closer. They're using the robots to melt the permafrost." The general's voice comes, shaky and unsettled. In all his years he's never seen such a bold move by the enemy. The Kingdom of Snows is usually protected by the temperature. Large glaciers lined the edges of the Kingdom, on one side leading south towards Seaworthy, and the other leading towards the Northern Reach.

Things had never been this bad in the Kingdom. The Horde was using a new kind of robot, one with the ability to burn its way through the ice without resistance. The siege had begun a week ago, but now Hordak was on their doorstep.

"Do we cancel Princess Prom, Princess?" The general asks, uneasy.

Princess Prom is a liability, potentially inviting the enemy in. But that might be just what the Kingdom of Snows needs- to appear

to let their guard down. Frosta thinks hard for a moment, before her eyes find the General's as a strategy forms behind them.

"No. We keep it open for everyone." An impish, sinister smirk crawls across her face. "Let them come."

"Princess Prom is tomorrow, 'Dor. You got any idea what you're gonna wear?" Catra lays on Adora's bed, head hanging over the edge as Adora gets ready for the day.

"Princess Prom?" Adora tilts her head, her voice still a deep timbre. Her memories still hadn't returned, not yet anyways. Catra found herself wondering if they ever would, as Adora adjusted more and more to Bright Moon life post-amnesia.

The Adora of now was less impulsive and definitely more confident than before. Her time with Shadow Weaver had erased the memory of trauma she had suffered the last few years, bringing a personality that had been buried deep to the surface.

And Catra was finding herself infatuated with that personality. The Adora of now was an utter dork. A little unaware sometimes, but positively amazing. It almost made Catra a little sad, because Adora was hiding it under years of trauma.

Should Catra even call it amazing? Or was it wrong of her to find herself captivated by a person who Adora just wasn't anymore? She decides not to dwell on it as she swings herself to a sitting position on the bed.

"Yeah. Princess Prom. It's this big event where all the princesses get together for a ball. It's being held in the Kingdom of Snows, where Frosta lives."

Adora turns to Catra, visibly confused. "Frosta?"

Catra chuckles. "Right, you don't know her. She's the princess up there. This will be a great time to recruit her to the rebellion."

Adora nods with a grin. "Does this mean I get to wear a dress?"

"You can wear whatever you like! I don't really do dresses so I'll be wearing a suit." Catra smiles. "You even get to bring a date, if you choose!"

Adora blushes. "I'll have to keep that in mind." She turns back to the mirror, straightening her white shirt up. "It's still so weird."

"What is?" Catra tilts her head.

"This." Adora turns back, gesturing at her body. "Until now I had no idea this was what I wanted. So many things are making sense, but I also have so many questions. How did I do it? How does Shadow Weaver know about it?" She sighs.

"That's a lot of baggage to unpack. Your memory will come back soon enough, Adora."

"I hope so."

The days since Entrapta's death had been hard. Her memory was honored with a mural on the same wall as King Micah's, albeit smaller and more isolated from the King's. It was beautiful, showing the Tech Princess amongst her robots in an epic battle against the Horde.

So Mermista stares at this mural, wondering why Entrapta had to die. Why the Horde had to keep destroying. Why she lives and others don't. Her mind wanders to the moment she decided to join the Alliance. Adora and Catra had just fought off the Horde invasion of Salineas. Why has she decided to join then?

Who or what was she fighting for, if it was all pointless anyways?

These questions crossed her mind as she stared, the mural seeming to come alive in front of her. She had been one of the last to see the woman alive, to have fought alongside her. Mermista finds unusual, strange emotions bubbling up inside of her. Was this grief?

"It's strange that she's gone." A voice comes. Mermista turns her head to see Catra. Patches of empty skin cover her arms and wrists where her fur had been ripped out. "I only knew her a short while but- but I feel like she was one of my best friends." Catra shakes her head.

Mermista nods, looking back at the mural. "She was a little strange, but good strange." A chuckle emits from Catra's mouth, causing Mermista to groan. "This is why I don't do gushy stuff."

Catra smiles. "But it's good for you. Memories are a good thing. I'm glad you were fond of her."

"You know, sometimes you really sound like her." Mermista smirks.

"Like Entrapta?" Catra raises a brow.

"No, like your mom. Sometimes you get all queenly and it reminds me of her." Mermistra grins. "Sometimes you can be a pain in the ass though."

Catra responds to this by punching Mermista's arm lightly. "Someone's gotta keep you out of trouble." Catra starts to walk towards the archway leading out of the room. "I'll see you tonight. Don't be late, we have a good impression to make on Frosta."

Mermista groans. She hates parties.

The boat ride to the Kingdom of Snows is long and grueling. Catra hates the water and the cold, but hates listening to Sea Hawk's weird shanties even more. The sound of sharpening a rusty steel blade might be more enjoyable to her than the singing at the moment.

Thankfully they're almost there, according to their singing doofus of a captain. Only another hour or so and they'd be at prom. Catra finds herself needing a break, retreating into the cabin of the Dragon's Daughter III for a moment before Sea Hawk gives her a splitting headache.

What she finds inside surprises her. The sight of Adora, sitting on the bed inside with her head in her hands is not what she was expecting. Catra's heightened hearing doesn't pick up any sobs, so Adora must be more stressed out than anything.

She sits down beside the blonde, causing her to yelp and bolt upright.

"Shit, Catra, you scared me." Adora mutters, her voice finding little hints of femininity in itself as she stares at the cabin walls.

"You've been practicing." Catra giggles.

"Well shit, yeah, of course I have. I want to make a good impression on this Frosta person and I look and sound like a freak." Adora groans.

"You do not. You look lovely, Adora. I don't even think your voice is giving anything away. You're doing great." Catra fires Adora a thumbs up.

"I don't feel like I am. I'm still coping with this. With shit I didn't even realize I wanted. It's not exactly easy when your last memories are of being a fairly masculine Horde grunt and suddenly you're a princess. And you love being the princess more than you ever did the grunt." Her head falls back into her palms.

"I'm sorry. I didn't realize it was so hard for you to cope with." Catra grits her teeth.

A call comes from the upper deck, the voice of Sea Hawk. "Land ho!"

Adora stands up, straightening out her red dress and brushing it off. "Guess I better go find Perfuma."

"Perfuma? Why?" Catra raises an eyebrow.

"I asked her to go with me. You said we could bring a date." Adora says nonchalantly as she walks towards the cabin door.

A pang of betrayal strikes through Catra's heart as the blonde closes the door behind her. Adora? Going with the flower princess? A wave of hurt rises through her, as her hands ball into fists. What was this emotion tearing through her? Adora could go with anyone she liked, but Catra still feels angry. It should be her.

Her palms bleed a little bit from how hard she digs her nails into her skin, the taste of blood filling her mouth as she bites her lip hard enough to draw it. This wasn't anger, this wasn't betrayal. It was jealousy. A jealousy that sought only to slip Catra into a painful sadness.

She wipes the blood from her hands on her suit, staining it a little. She growls in frustration before shrugging it off and standing up to leave.

"Whoa, are you ok?" Bow's voice comes as Catra steps out onto the deck.

Cold, crisp air washes over her fur, causing her to shiver a little as she steps over to the edge of the boat. "I'm fine, Bow." Catra rolls her eyes. The boy steps beside her, a look of concern growing on his face. She leans against the railing, staring out into the sea.

The jealousy threatens to boil over. She's trying to calm herself down, to tell herself it's just a brief thing, but she doesn't believe a damn word. Adora chose Perfuma over her. Was she not good enough? Was she too much for Adora? How could Adora just pick someone she barely knows.

I guess she barely knows me now too.

The thought tears through her like glass shards. Adora has no idea who she is. Who Catra is. Why should she trust her? It was all her fault she even got captured anyway.

"You're bleeding, Catra!" Bow's voice finds its way through her thoughts, echoing around in her head like the ringing of a bell, louder and louder before-

The anger overflows.

"I said-" Catra's jealousy overflows, a wave of rage bursting forward like water from a broken dam. "I'M FINE!" She drops to a sitting position against the edge of the deck, cupping her face in her hands.

"Catra…" Bow starts.

Catra's rage clouds her thoughts. Everybody here is such a goody two-shoes. Her life has been fucked from day one and these people think they know her? How dare they? HOW DARE THEY?

"Don't Catra me. All you've ever gotten is everything you wanted in life. All ANY OF YOU HAVE. I LOST MY DAD WHEN I WAS FOURTEEN, THEN I GET TO BE TORTURED BY HIS MURDERER AND MY MOM RESENTS ME FOR EVERYTHING I'VE EVER DONE." She's screaming now, causing most of the other occupants on the boat to turn and see what the commotion is about.

"Catra-"

"Fuck OFF, Perfuma! I don't care!" Catra hops up, turning to see that they were docked and jumping off the boat onto the ice below. She runs, runs faster than she's run ever before. Her bare feet feel frozen as they touch the layer of permafrost covering the ground.

Then suddenly she's back to the day her dad died. She's fourteen and stupid to the world around her, running through the woods as

fast as she can just to get away from the horrible news. Tears run down her face as she barrels into a wall of ice blockading the kingdom's doors. She falls backwards, landing on her back and hitting her head.

A flash of light later and Catra's unconscious.

"Holy shit." A voice above Catra says. Her left eye opens, staring up at a familiar pink and sparkly Force Captain of the Horde. Beside her is Scorpia, eyeing her with a raised eyebrow.

She hops to her feet, immediately extending her claws. "What the hell are you doing here?"

"Easy there, wildcat." Scorpia says, using her pincers to make a 'calm' gesture.

"Easy?!" Catra's voice squeaks. "You tried to kill me not a few weeks ago!"

"Not kill you, just lightly injure." Glimmer says, nodding.

"It doesn't matter! Why are you here?!" Catra glares.

"Because we were invited." Scorpia says matter-of-factly.

Catra's jaw drops. "Why would they invite you?"

"She's a princess." Glimmer chuckles.

Catra's eyes dart between the two of them incredulously. "Scorpia. Scorpia who is a Force Captain."

"Yes." Another voice interjects. Catra turns to see Frosta, princess of the Kingdom of Snows, standing next to her. The blockade that Catra slammed into was lowered, and two guards now stood at it. "All princesses are invited to Prom. That includes Scorpia and whoever she invites as her plus one."

Catra turns back, glaring at Glimmer. The shorter woman cackles, walking through the gate and into the prom as if she wasn't a force of evil.

Catra doesn't want to go back to the group. Not yet. So she follows them in.

Glimmer eyes Scorpia with a knowing, evil smirk. Hordak had put the duo up to this, hoping to use Princess Prom to draw the Kingdom's guard down.

His trust in Shadow Weaver faltered after her failures during the magicat's rescue. Her deceptive, manipulative ways had proven her too disloyal. He promised Glimmer power if this job was done right, and boy is Glimmer eager to prove.

She had directed Entrapta (whomst she and Scorpia had discovered hiding in a vent) to build the permafrost melting bots, hoping to use it as enough distraction to infiltrate the kingdom. Once the pair were in and Frosta was distracted, the bots were to break the final layer of ice and pour into the kingdom.

But that was only after Glimmer had gotten on Frosta's good side, and maybe under Catra's skin too.

A smirk draws across her face. She turns to the magicat, who stands several feet behind her. "Hey, Catra." Glimmer chuckles. "Are you here by yourself?"

The woman doesn't look up at her, instead choosing to keep walking with her arms folded. "Yeah. So what?"

"Where's your precious Adora?" Glimmer sneers. Catra walks up to her, stopping in her tracks. Until now, Glimmer hadn't noticed how tall Catra was, having a clear foot and then some on her.

"It doesn't matter where she is." Catra says in a low voice.

"Well, how about you hang out with us for the evening?" The evil gears turn in Glimmer's head, a perfect manipulation tactic forming.

"Why the hell would I hang out with my kidnappers?" Catra groans, walking past Glimmer and towards the center of the ballroom.

"Doesn't seem like there's a lotta choices here." Glimmer giggles. "Come on, now, Catra. Come dance with your dear sister."

Catra freezes. "The dance hasn't even started yet. Be good and I'll think about it."

Good.

Catra approaches the stage of the ballroom, where Frosta's throne was set up. Two guards flanked the young princess on either side, a warning to those who might try anything funny while prom was on.

Frosta can't be much younger than Catra. Fourteen, maybe fifteen at most. She has an angry, distant look in her eye that Catra recognizes too well as the look of someone who has too many lives at stake to have fun. It almost reminds Catra of her mother, and she supposes by extension, herself.

"Princess Frosta." Catra bows.

"If you're here to try to get me to join the Alliance, save it. Prom isn't the time for politics." Frosta growls. One of the guards places her hand on the princess's shoulder.

"I merely offer you a greeting from Bright Moon, your majesty." Catra nods her head. She knows this won't be so easy, especially with how stressed Frosta seems.

"Your greeting is accepted, Princess Catra. Though I still feel as though you have an ulterior motive. Do you understand that my people are under attack?" Frosta's stare is intentionally dark, a thousand lives lying behind it as her words leave her lips.

"I do, your majesty. That's why Bright Moon wishes to help any way we can." Catra says, a determined glare hiding her nerves.

"Enough. This will wait until after Prom. Do not mention it to me again." Frosta gestures for the guards to escort Catra away.

Catra huffs, turning around and walking down the small steps back onto the ballroom floor. Of course Frosta wouldn't consider it during Prom, this was a celebration, not a war room.

She looks up from where she had been staring at her feet to see Adora and Perfuma, just now arriving in the hall.

Oh no. Oh gods.

Her feet move faster than her mind does as she takes off running. A small staircase hides in the corner of the room next to the incline leading to Frosta's throne, one that hopefully would take her somewhere high and away from Adora.

When she arrives at the top she's greeted by the sight of the roof, overlooking the icy barren land below. She climbs onto it, sitting down with her legs against her chest, as she watches the aurora borealis that arcs across the sky.

Why, why? Why did she have to pick her? Am I not good enough? Am I a joke to her?

Tears roll down Catra's cheeks, her face growing cold as the air cools them. She hugs her legs tighter to her chest, completely despondent. She doesn't want to be down there, to do any of this anymore. She just wants to disappear.

A loud thud startles her out of her thoughts, causing her to jump to her feet. She watches as Glimmer teleports next to the hatch leading to the roof, helping Scorpia up through.

"Ugh. What the hell do you want?" Catra rolls her eyes, burying her face in her hands.

"To have a little chat." Glimmer chuckles and sits down beside Catra.

"We're not friends. You can't manipulate me by pretending to be mine."

Catra catches Glimmer looking out at the Aurora from the corner of her eye. "What if we were?"

"We're not. I'm leaving." Catra stands, turning on her heels towards the hatch.

"To go where? Back to your friends?" Glimmer's tone has an edge that stops Catra dead in her tracks.

"Fuck you." Catra's words leave her lips faster than she has time to consider them. "You don't know any of them."

"The moment you saw Adora you ran! You're not exactly on good terms right now, are you?" Glimmer says, smirking.

"So what? What's that got to do with me?" Catra says, her tone more hurt than angry.

"I'm saying, maybe we could help you get a little…revenge." Glimmer grins, innocently enough.

What comes from Catra's mouth next isn't a choice. Pure frustration and anger clouds her judgment as she turns to Glimmer.

"I'm in."

"Princess." A hand taps Frosta on the shoulder. "A word?"

Frosta looks up at the General, a sigh of exasperation leaving her mouth before she nods and stands.

"Excuse me. There is an urgent matter I must attend to." She says to her guests, before following the man through the side door. Her smile turns to a glare. "What now? Is it really so important that it couldn't wait until after prom?"

"Your highness-" The general hesitates. "The bots have breached the wall."

Frosta turns pale. "Fuck. They're early. How long until they're here?" She shifts nervously on each foot, wringing her hands.

"Estimates say 16 hours." The general shakes his head. "What is your plan, your highness?"

"I can't reveal our situation entirely to Princes Bright Moon yet. Just hang tight until I give the word. Try to keep them attritioned at the wall and buy us some time while those Horde commanders are distracted."

"What is the endgame to this?" The general raises his eyebrow quizzically.

"Survive."

"Come on, Catra!" Glimmer smirked at the magicat, gesturing towards the center of the ballroom. Loud music played, the kind only Catra's mother might enjoy: uptight violin with precise, never dissonant notes over cellos.

Glimmer bows at Catra from the dance floor. She reaches her hand out, eyeing the taller woman with a smirk. "May I have this dance?" She says with a chuckle.

"Of course, m'lady." Catra grins back. Once Adora sees the pair she's gonna lose her shit. Catra twirls Glimmer around, catching her and bringing her low to the ground. She can sense the eyes staring at them, a twisted, sickening kind of enjoyment washing over Catra at their horror.

The feeling unsettles her, causing her to lose her footing.

"What the hell are you doing?" Glimmer growls.

"Sorry, just got distracted." Catra says, more sheepishly than intended.

"Catra?!" Adora's voice howls over the crowd. "What do you think you're doing? That's Glimmer!"

The pair stop dancing altogether, Catra grinning at Adora with a bit of malice. "What's wrong Adora?" She says, almost mocking

her.

"You're dancing with the enemy." Adora says, her face turning red. "What's wrong with you?? I thought I could trust you…but all you've proven is how selfish you are!"

"Oh, says the one who went and ran off with Princess Flower!"

"No. Shut up. You just wanted me all to yourself, right? That's what that was back on the boat, huh?" Tears roll down Adora's face. "I can't remember, Catra. I just ended up in this new world, this new body. You're the only person who hasn't looked at me like a freak. How could you?" With that she runs away, leaving Catra feeling like the worst person who's ever lived.

"Geez, what's her problem?" Glimmer drawls, causing Catra to glare at her.

So this is the Princess Alliance. Infighting teenagers. I should have expected nothing less. Frosta thinks, before reminding herself that she's not much younger than those on the dance floor currently.

The one who interests her most is the blonde. The so-called 'She-Ra.' She wants to pull her aside, inform her of the coming

disaster, but it seems pointless if she and Princess Catra were going to fight.

When the bots arrived they would be ready, regardless. She was sure She-Ra would be enough to distract them from the Kingdom of Snows. Just how much time that would be she didn't know.

Estimates say the bots are picking up the pace, which puts them at around eight hours away. As long as the Force Captains were distracted (she thinks this as she watches Scorpia devour some of the our d'oeuvres) they would be at a disadvantage, unable to command the coming swarm. The infighting was perfect for the Kingdom for now. Soon they would capture the Horde command and put a halt to the invasion.

She would force them to negotiate.

Adora sits with her knees pulled to her chest on the edge of the dark balcony. The palace really was bigger than it looked. Were it a Horde fortress that might be the point, but for a kingdom of snow people it surprised her.

But everyone acted like she shouldn't be surprised. Up until two weeks ago she had apparently been some other person. Some other collection of traumatizing memories that made her who she was.

She didn't even know how to control She-Ra. That stupid sword chose a different person. She wasn't that Adora. She didn't even know if she would be when her memories returned.

She climbs on top of the large balcony railing, staring out at the frozen lake upon which the palace sat. Her dress whips in the cold wind that brushes through her legs. An aurora borealis sits overhead, almost perfectly capturing the scene.

She can't help but feel like something is inherently wrong with her. She could just step off this stupid ledge and let it be someone else's problem. She had every right to decide who she was, didn't she? So why should it be her who the world's problems fall on.

Adora hovers a foot over the ledge, closing her eyes and just balancing. Feeling the call of the void that tells her to just submit herself to gravity. It would be so easy.

"Adora?" A calm voice says, not one she immediately expects to hear.

She opens her eyes, placing her foot firmly back on the balcony. She sits down on the ledge with her legs hanging over and just stares, not giving her guest much of a response at all as he sits down beside her.

"What do you want, Bow?" Adora says with a sigh.

"What happened in there?" Bow raises an eyebrow, concerned.

"Catra danced with Glimmer, that's what. She wanted to get back at me for going with Perfuma." Adora lifts her knees to her chest.

Bow groans. "She always gets so reckless. It's like… her fatal flaw. As long as I've known her she just pushes and pushes and doesn't ever think!" He laughs, a sort of fondness coming through.

"Reckless is right. I can't remember a damn thing and she gets jealous over something so insignificant."

"Well, to be fair, it was about as insignificant to her as Glimmer dancing with her was to you." Bow points out.

Adora's eyes widen in realization, a loud, husky groan emitting from deep in her throat. The groan carries on, soon turning into a scream of rage as a fist meets the balcony ledge. "I am such an idiot!" She yells.

Bow scratches the back of his head. "Well, let's just call it even on both of your parts."

An explosion sounds from inside the castle. Bow and Adora both briefly look at each other before breaking into a sprint. Flames climb the tapestries and robots pour in by the tens. Scorpia and Catra are fighting on the main floor while Frosta deals with more bots on the upper level.

Adora readies her sword and jumps over the edge onto the main floor.

Catra swipes an artificial claw at Scorpia, her left hand instead getting caught in her pincer as the larger woman twists her arm. A loud pop crackles through the air as white hot pain fires up her hand. Catra suppresses a cry of pain, choosing instead to swipe at Scorpia's face with her bad hand.

She catches Scorpia on the cheek, causing her to stumble back as blood pours down her face. An arrow lands squarely against her chest, exploding in a tangle of ropes that ties Scorpia's arms to her sides.

"You know, Pincers, I actually think we might have been friends in a different life." Catra sneers, ignoring the flames in her left arm as Bow approaches from the side.

"Catra-"

"No time for chatter, they're gonna burn the whole place to the ground!" Catra's face must have twitched, because Bow's face changes from his 'Soldier' face to his 'Medic' one. He eyes her arm, which she was holding with the other. "Catra, your arm."

"No time." Catra growls through gritted teeth. "Let's find Frosta."

The pair make way, running past Mermista and Perfuma both doing battle with bots of their own. Mermista was clearly having an easier time than Perfuma. Not many plants grow in a frozen wasteland.

The flower princess was absolutely scary with what she could muster anyways. A twisted, angry look had grown on Perfuma's face as she used the potted plants and the underground roots to take out bots left and right, a sort of hatred Catra didn't think she was capable of brewing behind her eyes.

As Catra runs past Perfuma, she spots the young snow princess, a spear made of ice in her hand as she expertly stabs a robot through its middle. The girl couldn't be more than fifteen, something Catra found all too disheartening. She too was a child soldier and she too was forced to grow up too early.

Why must children fight this war? Angella's voice echoes in her head. Her mother had uttered those same words many times. They had never meant much to Catra until now.

Frosta continues to stab and stab and stab at the robot, as if hoping that somehow it might stop the invasion. She was losing. The bots were melting the ice and the Alliance was outnumbered. Catra's heart sinks as she realizes they have to retreat.

"Your majesty!" Catra calls.

Frosta turns a glaring eye to Catra. "What do you want, Brightmoon? I'm a little busy here."

"We can't win this fight! The palace is lost!" Catra says, a hint of defeat in her voice.

"I am not abandoning the palace." Just then, two more robots jump in beside the one Frosta was going all out on. Her eyes widen and Catra swears she catches a tear forming. She looks around, a hopelessness seeming to work its way past her stubborn exterior.

"On your order, sir!" Catra hears one of the generals say.

Frosta freezes the bots around her, hopping atop the ice of one of them and looking down at her remaining regiment. She takes on a commanding air as her voice echoes throughout the palace.

"Retreat! Everyone! Fall back!" The shouts sound too weathered to be the fifteen year old princess. To Catra they should be coming from a hardened commander. Someone with experience. Maybe Frosta has that after all, Catra has learned to not underestimate her.

Adora's hand grabs Catra's bad arm as she pulls her through a hole in the wall towards the boats. A cry of pain emits from Catra's vocal cords as her broken arm protests.

Adora doesn't even look back at her- a cold and calculating look forming in her eye instead. She wasn't going to stop until they were safe.

The infirmary aboard the Snows flagship was cramped, but usable. Adora had seen worse in her time in the Horde, maybe even more in the memories she doesn't have anymore. She's holding Catra in her arms, emitting a blush from the grumpy princess as she lays her down on a cot.

"You didn't have to carry me the whole way once we got on the boat. My legs work." Catra mutters.

"You still need to save your strength. The battle isn't over, Catra."

Catra concedes with a nod that brings Adora a small amount of relief. At least they were back on speaking terms again. Whatever happened back there, at the dance, she might as well just forget it. Catra mattered more to her as a friend than whatever petty argument they were having.

Just then, Bow enters the room with a plate and a grin. "Look what I saved!"

Catra raises an eyebrow. "You saved…rolls?"

"The chefs actually brought them on board before the Horde attacked." Bow says sheepishly. "But I thought it might take your mind off things."

Catra's eyes widen, before a familiar raspy cackle escapes her lips. "You fucking dork!" She says fondly. "Get over here dummy!"

Bow grins, sitting down between Catra's cot and Adora. Catra props herself against the wall, looking towards the doorways expectantly.

"Medics might be a bit tied up right now." Bow offers. "They're still bringing the injured aboard. Frosta included."

"Frosta? What happened to Frosta?" Catra inquires.

Bow grimaces. "She was hid

ing a nasty set of second and third degree burns from the flamethrower bots. Apparently her arms and neck are gonna scar up pretty bad."

"That explains the high scarf. Girl was trying to seem tough. I know someone else like that." Adora grins, eyeing Catra.

The magicat rolls her eyes before offering a smirk, causing the pair to laugh. Adora finds herself hoping that things will work out in the end.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much to Rinii for betaing this one!

Walk

Chapter Summary

Adora finds herself stranded in the Northern Reach

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Remember how we used to be?

A woman crosses the icy snow of the Northern Reach, wearing nothing but a long sleeve shirt and pants to keep her warm as each step seems to be more arduous than the last. Her sweat turns to cold steel against her skin, the wounds scattered all over her body exposed to the cold elements.

When the sky was full of stars?

Shrapnel made of wood and metal was embedded all over her body, one had come so close to her ear to take off a small chunk. Her blonde hair whips in her face as the wind picks up across the cold wasteland. Adrenaline keeps her walking aimlessly, searching for something or someone to keep her alive.

Remember how we used to feel?

The woman's eyes catch a red light blinking in the distance. This was normally something she would disregard without another

thought. She was a Hordesman, blinking lights were part of her everyday life for the better part of nineteen years. But this light meant something to her. It meant there was a Horde outpost ahead, one which she could find food and rest at. These outposts were usually unmanned, really only serving as scientific centers. This meant she could likely use Shadow Weaver's codes to get inside.

Those days would never end

The sterile gray building comes into view through the darkness and snow. It wasn't huge, but she didn't need it to be. She just needed it to be stocked with medicine and food.

She's been careful to this point to cover her footprints so no one follows her. She especially makes sure as she approaches the building, not wanting to alert anyone to her presence inside in case her former allegiance showed up.

As she approaches the cold steel door a lightning bolt of pain shoots up her leg. Good timing, she supposes. She has to get this hunk of metal out of her leg before it becomes infected. She could treat her own wounds, but an infection was not something she might be able to perform basic first aid on.

She taps the panel beside the door, lighting it up. It displays a green overlay with a large, all capitalized Etherian text on it.

ACCESS CODE REQUIRED

She quickly enters Shadow Weaver's codes, desperate to get out of the wind and snow. A loud, grating buzz indicates that she's entered the codes wrong. She frowns, entering them again. Another buzz. Panic begins to settle in her gut.

Fuck. Fuck. Fuck. She thinks. She won't be able to get in without those codes. Shadow Weaver must have changed them after Glimmer found out about her parents.

Glimmer

She quickly enters in Glimmer's codes. The two had shared with each other in case they ever got separate ranks. Glimmer called it her way of 'showing the Horde who the future bosses were.'

The thought makes the woman chuckle as the door hisses open. At least she remembers that. Moments are coming back to her faster and faster. Large blows to the head will do that to you, she supposes.

Her eyes dart around as she steps inside the outpost. As industrial and utilitarian as any Horde outpost she has ever seen. In the corner was a ration bar dispenser with two types of bars to dispense. Across the way is a white curtain leading into another room, either the barrack or the bathroom, she supposes. Storage shelves full of electronics and gadgets line most of the walls, save

for a corner with countertops for performing experiments. A single table sat in the middle between those counters, for performing experiments or taking breaks.

So far, so good, she thinks. She presses the button to seal the door behind her, setting it to lock before limping over to the curtain. She pulls it to the side to reveal the barrack, a room lined with cots. Another curtain sat beyond it, which she assumes is the bathroom.

Once she pulls aside the second curtain she's relieved to find a full first aid kit. The Horde at least prepared for most everything. She begins the painful task of peeling off her freezing shirt and pants. Her arms and legs ache sorely as she removes her outer garments. Her eyes find the mirror, assessing the damage her body had sustained. She was cut on every side, burns covering her left arm and side. Pieces of metal stuck out of a particularly deep wound in her stomach.

She chuckles. She'd felt worse pain. She *would* feel worse pain. Cleaning these wounds would be a bitch, for sure. Shame. If she had her sword this would be easy. Nothing ever is she supposes.

A loud sigh escapes her lungs as she pulls open the first aid kit. She finds the pair of medical pliers and gets to work on the wound in her side first. The first bit of shrapnel comes easy, the second just as quick. When she gets to the third, the mere touch causes blinding pain to shoot through her stomach. She clenches her teeth, grabbing hold of it and pulling as hard as she can.

White hot pain causes her to almost pass out. A loud groan escapes her lips as the large jagged piece of metal leaves her abdomen. She stumbles a bit, her stomach threatening to lurch in response to the pain.

She leans against the sink, heaving and struggling to breath as the pain courses through her. It almost makes her angry, brings her a certain kind of pain she can only describe as rage.

One down, a hundred to go. She thinks.

This would be a long night.

The sound of guns and artillery ring in your ear. It's hard to focus on anything as the battle rages on both land and sea. The boat you're standing on is a standard Moonstone *class gunship, rocking back and forth with the crashing of waves.*

Your sword was gone. Again. You couldn't believe you lost it after everything back in the Fright Zone. It had been out of your hand overboard during the initial scuffle. Thankfully you were more than She-Ra, but she certainly would come in handy.

Splintered wood litter the deck, a result of the cannons from the Horde fleet. Mermista had taken care of the first gunship, but she

had quickly become tangled up with the others. Frosta and Perfuma were nowhere to be found, either. You hope they're tough enough to stick it out.

A familiar voice finds your ear. The voice of Brightmoon's commander. She screams orders at the crew of the ship, clearly desperate to break through the Horde defenses.

A cannon blast suddenly makes contact with the starboard side of the boat where you stand, sending pieces of wood piercing into your flesh and flinging you back onto the deck.

The commander screams your name as your head slams against the deck, a white flash of static blinking across your eyes before darkness takes you.

The woman bolts upright, sweat soaking the standard-issue Horde shirt she wears. The dream was too real, a recap of the events of just a day prior. Her head pounds and hands shake as she stumbles off the cot.

Water. She thinks, realizing just how dehydrated she is. A pain shoots through her left side, down into her leg. She wonders if the shrapnel had struck a nerve as she approaches the rations, finding a can of water and cracking it open.

She guzzles it down faster than she should, a wave of nausea overcoming her briefly as the water hits her stomach all at once. It's a brief respite from the pain currently throbbing in her leg, but not exactly a pleasant one.

Another pain also plagues her: emotional pain. The surge of memories coming back to her is overwhelming, the events leading up to this day frustrating and reminding of just who she is: a loser.

An audible groan leaves her mouth as she gets on her feet, the pain both from her leg and her memories attacking on two fronts. It's probably for the best if she works out; should keep her on her toes and gives her something to take her mind off things.

She curses aloud, the Horde language slipping out of her mouth. She barely spoke in it anymore, it being a relic of her past as a cadet. Most were taught two languages: Horde and Etherian Standard. This was by design, so as to be able to communicate more effectively with locals as well as with each other. Her accent had even faded from her time in Brightmoon.

Most spoke Standard by the time she left, though. Anyone who spoke Standard could join the Horde, which naturally created a higher number of Standard speakers than Horde. Most internal affairs were handled in Horde, and on the battlefield Standard was used.

Not that it mattered much to the woman. Her native tongue might as well be alien to her anymore. She hadn't spoken it since before the skiff crash nearly a year ago and it had only been in a brief assessment. It was mainly used because Hordak spoke it natively and struggled with Standard.

Her thoughts dissipate as she stretches out, a weight in each hand. She presses up, performing a chest press.

So far, so good. She thinks.

Thirty reps later she stands. Pain radiates down her leg, nearly causing her to crumble back to the ground. She lifts her shirt, checking the large wound on her left side.

What greets her is the inflamed, bright red appearance of an infection. She groans in frustration, having thought she solved this before with the cleaning of the wound.

She steps back to the aid kit, pulling it open and digging around for antibiotics. She could take some oral ones in addition to stitching the wound properly. This would probably hurt like a mother, though: the local anesthetic is all used up.

Ugh. Fine. She thinks, not really giving a shit either way. What's a little more pain? She's so used to it at this point that if something were wrong she might not know right away.

She pours it over the wound, white hot pain greeting her at the first touch of the liquid. She curses again, biting down on her lip harder than intended in an attempt to fight the pain.

The pain reminds her almost of an electrical shock, something she knew all too well. As if on cue, her arm tingles with residual pain, bringing back memories of an abusive mother figure in a formative time of her life.

She hopes she's treated the infection in time. Getting ill will only make her situation worse. She can't stay here forever, only until she comes up with a plan for signaling Brightmoon. She wonders if, maybe even hopes that, they think she's dead. The pressure of being She-Ra has been building on her these past few months. The return of her memories only serve to remind her of the anxiety of being the savior of so many.

Her thoughts wander back to Catra. The last time they spoke was before the battle. They had fought back in the Kingdom of Snows. The woman had maybe said some things her friend hadn't appreciated, and finds herself cursing Shadow Weaver for the memory loss.

The battle itself had begun like any other naval battle. Horde ships had overwhelmed the Snows quickly, splintering their boats to pieces and scattering the armies onto land. The Horde then took to burning the Northern Reach as they fought.

Frosta had drawn a fallback line Adora had never made it to. She had fallen off their gunboat into ice cold water, passing out after a long, deathly cold swim to shore. When she came to the Horde had advanced, leaving only the charred remains of the battlefield for Adora to wander through.

So she wandered for what was probably hours, maybe even days. It was nighttime all day at the Northern Reach this time of year, which meant it wouldn't be easy to track the time whatsoever. The only light she had seen for that time was the tower outside the outpost.

The tower . She thinks. *It has to have a comms relay.*

That might be her ticket to contacting the Alliance if she can reprogram the signals. Shouldn't be too hard, as at the very least it was standard for the Horde to keep an updated manual of operations at these outposts. Not everyone could train on it right away and a reference was important for smooth transitions of crew.

Her stomach gurgles, breaking the hopeful train of thought. She should eat before she does anything. Her eyes dart around the room, finding a shelf with prepackaged ration bars.

A brief cackle escapes her lips. Of course it was ration bars. She can only hope it's the good ones as she stands, limping over to the shelf.

Ugh. She groans aloud. It was the brown ones, the ones she had always hated. Her disgust turns to amusement. Food in Brightmoon had spoiled her, as she never really cared before now. Neither ration bar type was very good, to be honest.

She splits open the package, biting into the ration bar as if she'd never eaten before. She honestly can't remember when she had eaten last. Everything had happened so fast the last few days, she'd be surprised if it had been a week.

The bar has a gooey texture, like that of wet clay. The brown bars had always tasted like chemicals to her, with a salty aftertaste not unlike that of seawater. They were disgusting, but at least they were food.

She downs the remaining bar, turning her attention to the relay. There has to be a control panel somewhere around here. She spots it fast, sitting in the corner with the scientific equipment. Not surprising, the relay was probably how they sent data back to the Fright Zone.

She stands, her infected leg shrieking in pain as she limps over to the panel. It's rectangular, with a large symbol like a wave on the front to indicate communications. She grabs the latch on the side and pulls, receiving in response only resistance. She groans: the box is latched shut.

Her eyes dart around the room, looking for a place the key might be hiding. Her eyes settle on something that would work almost

as well: a crowbar. She steps over and picks it up, turning to eye the panel. This would be a pain, but it would work.

She jams the crowbar into the crack separating the door from the rest of the panel. She bends it, causing the metal to creak loudly. She pushes harder, louder creaking emanating. Soon the panel door comes free with a very loud *pop.*

When Adora peeks inside, she groans loudly. The lights are red inside, indicating the relay is switched off at the source. That would mean she has to climb the tower outside in the blizzard and power it.

Fuck. She thinks.

Before long she's standing outside in the cold, staring up at the relay tower. Thankfully it wasn't the tallest she'd seen. It stood around sixty feet in the air, blinking as if it was still alive.

Maybe it's a severed ground connection? Adora first checks the connections leading to the tower itself. Nothing seems out of place there, which means it's likely topside. This wasn't going to be fun. The wind is picking up and the snow is pouring down now. She has to be fast.

Ignoring the pain in her left leg, she climbs towards the heavens, the cold metal of the ladder threatening to stick to her hand with

every step. She finds the climb isn't so bad if she focuses on the pain in her leg rather than the distance she has to go.

About halfway up, an extreme gust of wind nearly blows her off the ladder. She only barely catches herself and hangs on with one hand, but it’s enough to not only send adrenaline coursing through her body but remind her of how little time she has.

When she reaches the top she's greeted by the sight of another panel. Thankfully this one isn't locked and flips open with ease. The problem is apparent as she looks inside: the relay's connection module to the ground is disconnected, making it impossible to use the panel inside. A few minutes of twisting wires together and the module is limping along again.

She looks down, dreading the trip back to the bottom for a moment before a huge gust of wind knocks her off her feet, threatening to send her much faster than she’d like. Another moment of quiet takes hold in the air and she quickly begins her descent to the ground.

The calm doesn't last long, though. Seconds later, another violent gust breaks her grip, causing her to tumble thirty feet to the ground, sending her already infected, injured leg slamming into the earth harder than she’d fallen during the skiff crash. It breaks with a loud and horrendous *snap* that sends shockwaves of pain through her body. She doesn't even realize at first that she's screaming in pain until her vocal cords choose to give out and nausea takes hold.

She's sitting in the snow, tears rolling down her cheeks as pain radiates from her hip all throughout her body. She'd have to crawl back inside and do the deed of setting the bone, which would make this pain seem minor in comparison. A million thoughts bounce around in her head before she shakes her head. She rolls onto her stomach, limping on hands and one knee back towards the door. Her knee gives out just as she crosses onto the square of pavement that sits in front of the door, causing her to land flat on her face with a *thud* .

She lets out a groan, rolling over and pulling herself up beside the door. Something catches in the corner of her eye and she turns her head, the comms tower now blinks a green light. It's receiving a signal.

She chuckles, reaches her hand up and presses the button to open the door, dragging herself inside rather painfully. The message would unfortunately need to wait until her leg was set. She drags herself along, shutting the door quickly and laying back on the ground of the outpost. Her emotions hit all at once as she lets out an angry growl and swings her fist wildly. It finds the floor, bruising her hand as she slams it down. She sits up, cupping her face and breathing deeply, before looking to her left.

Great, another injury. Not gonna be much left of me at this point. She thinks.

Through her hair she could see the first aid kit she had used to clean her wounds. It didn't have any kind of splint inside, which means unless the storage room has something Adora will need to improvise.

She climbs up, hopping on one leg and leaning over the counter next to the console. A few taps later and she's met with a simple screen inviting her to search the supplies of the outpost.

Query? It reads in Horde.

Adora types in "splint."

The console thinks for a moment before pinging a single option in storage. Adora finds herself sighing in relief. She would have to hop on one leg to find it, but luckily the console tells her exactly what bay it's in so she won’t have to look. Her hands leave the counter as she hops to the door just across the room, nearly toppling as she does. Her right hand meets the wall to steady herself as her left pushes the button to open the door. It's dark inside and a little cold.

Her eyes find row 3, where surplus medical supplies are kept. Hopping down the row she spots it. She has to resist the urge to pump her fist due to the need to steady herself on the shelves. Finally something was going her way! She grabs it and, before hopping back towards the door, she spots a crutch. Score!

She puts the crutch under her arm, walking with a bit of a limp due to its size. Her back finds the wall beside the door, where she prepares for the worst part. Gritting her teeth and looking at her throbbing leg, she opens the splint and preps it for use before reaching down. With a deep breath and some psyching herself up

she presses both hands against her thigh. Tears fill her eyes, the pain growing unfathomable as she increases the pressure gradually until: *pop* .

A scream of pain escapes her as the bone sets. She slides down the wall, tears pouring out of her eyes as she quickly tries to power through it and wrap the splint around her leg. Adora relaxes, drunk on adrenaline. Leaning back for a moment with a hysterical giggle, she grabs the crutch, standing with a groan and walking on it back to the console.

Adora navigates back to the comms relay where that message still waited for her. It blinked on the screen as if inviting her to open it. She taps it.

NORTHERN REACH OUTPOST B

This is an automated message to remind you of the routine inspection occurring today. Please be at your stations and ready. Glory be to the Horde.

Fuck. Would they still inspect it if it was empty? Adora doesn't know if she wants to find out. She quickly gathers the remnants of the medical kit, limping back on the crutch to the store room to put it back. As she plops the box back on the shelf she hears the whirr of the automatic door.

Fuck.

She pops the light off, hoping the inspector won't question the lights being on. She cringes as she hears not one, but multiple voices.

“Why'd we get stuck on inspection duty?” The voice is timid and familiar. “We’re all the way out in the middle of nowhere for a base that's empty.”

A voice responds in a reptilian language, causing memories to flood back to Adora.

Kyle and Rogelio.

“Oh, I guess you're right. If it was empty the lights would have been off.” Kyle mutters. “Anyone there? Survivors of the battle?” He calls out, a little half-heartedly.

Rogelio responds.

“Yeah, yeah. I’ll be careful, babe.” He mutters again. Adora can hear him walking towards the door of the store room.

Babe? She thinks, but before she can process it the door activates and opens with a loud *whoosh* . She readies the crutch, waiting for Kyle to turn the light on to strike.

Moments later he obliges.

Whack! He topples over.

“Fuck! Ow!” Kyle looks up, rubbing his head. “Adora?”

“Listen up, you two.” Adora smirks. “I was never here, understand?”

Kyle musters up as much courage as he can, puffing out his chest. “And why should we do that? We could capture you. Be heroes of the Horde.”

“You owe me firstly. I was the only one defending you through cadet training. Even Ro knows that.” A grunt of affirmation comes from the lizard man.

“Ok, but even then! Shadow Weaver might forget all about that!”

Adora cringes at the woman's name, before an idea overcomes her. “Ok, fine. You want me to play dirty? I'll tell her all the times you ever cheated on cadet exams.”

Kyle goes pale. “You knew that?”

Adora nods. “Just leave me alone and let me survive. We both know you don't really care about the cause. Just let me go, and no one has to remember this happened.x

Kyle looks to Rogelio. The lizard man silently nods. “But what if I call your bluff?”

“Do you want to find out?”

Kyle swallows. “You were never here. Ro and I will just take some snacks and leave. Deal?”

“Deal.”

Kyle quickly gathers the food, nodding at Ro and looking back to Adora with a sigh. “And…Adora. If you ever need a friend, one from the inside, we’re always willing to parley with you.”

Adora’s heart drops. This sweet boy was offering to meet in the middle. Maybe there was a chance for him. “Thanks, Ky.”

“Anytime ‘Dor.”

The two step out into the cold and begin their walk.

Once the pair leave, Adora immediately sits at the terminal again. She scrolls over the option labeled ‘transmit’ and pushes it. It immediately requests communication codes, which Adora happened to memorize during her first week in Brightmoon. Looks like it's coming in handy.

She pops them in, immediately beginning to type fast.

Alliance Allies

Mayday, Mayday.

I am currently sheltered in a Horde outpost roughly 20 clicks from the site of the naval battle that just took place in the Northern Reach. Limited food, at least enough for another two to three weeks. Need medical attention, a broken leg with an infection spreading to my abdomen.

Adora

She presses send, sighing in relief. Hopefully the Alliance gets it promptly. Maybe rescue will come quickly.

Rescue has not come quickly. It took a week for Bright Moon to respond that they were dispatching a team, which Adora promptly responded to with an affirmative message. It's been six days since then and she's starting to ration the food best she can, having lost more than twenty pounds. The only thing she can do is work out, to stay sane.

Her infection has eased, though her broken leg throbs without healing magic or painkillers. She hoped the antibiotics she picked were the right ones. Medical knowledge was Glimmer’s thing, not hers. She's been gritting her teeth through the ordeal, slowly growing accustomed to her life being this outpost for the time being. Honestly, her expectations have been defeated anyways. She thought she’d be dead by now.

There's enough rations to keep her fed for at least a month, thankfully. Medicine is scarce, but as long as she doesn't break any more bones she'll survive without it. No more stupid ideas, even necessary ones.

There is a shaving kit for those that want it, something that Adora is incredibly grateful for. She doesn't know how she'd survive dealing with both dysphoria and immense pain. At least one of those is taken care of.

She just hopes Catra and Bow are alright. She hasn't seen them in what feels like years at this point. All she wants to do is apologize to Catra for being a big dummy. She just hopes the magicat can forgive her for acting like a complete crazed moron.

Then, another thought comes to Adora. Her memories have slowly returned the last two weeks, finally breaking away into a recollection of the last few years of her life. She remembers all the ways Shadow Weaver tortured her, tortured Catra. A new emotion settles into her heart, one that gives her a sense of confidence: protectiveness. Something she’s always been the subject of, not the other way around.

Another memory also returns to her. The memory of standing on the edge of a balcony and contemplating whether to let herself fall. She’s not proud of it, but she doesn’t feel bad about it either. She actively considered whether the Alliance was better off without her. The only reason she stayed was because they deserved to have She-Ra at least.

She-Ra. Where does she even begin with She-Ra. She almost holds a resentment for the woman, even if it just is a superpowered version of her. Everyone loves She-Ra, forget about Adora. She almost wishes she’d never found the sword.

As she ponders these things, a loud knock emanates from the door. She fumbles, quickly standing up on her crutch and limping over to the door. She checks the camera feed beside the door to see the familiar faces of Bow and Frosta.

She sighs in relief, pressing the button and opening the door to let the pair in.

“Adora, your leg!” Bow immediately starts.

Adora waves her hand dismissively. “It's nothing. Just a broken bone or two.”

“Hell yeah! Taking it like a man!” Frosta's voice is more chipper than when Adora last heard it. She wonders if the young General had found good company in Brightmoon.”

“Moreso that there's no medical equipment here.” Adora chuckles, before her face grows somber. “Where's Catra?”

Bow's smile fades. “Oh, well. She had some tactical business to attend to back in Brightmoon. She wanted to come but couldn't find the time. Plus Scorpia kind of fractured her arm so she's been letting it heal.”

Adora sighs. “Alright, I suppose I'll give her that. What kind of business?”

“My people are taking refuge in Bright Moon. The Kingdom of Snows is..” Frosta clearly stifles the urge to break down into tears.

“It's half destroyed and occupied.”

Adora’s stomach drops. “I thought we won?”

“In a matter of speaking…” Bow starts. “The Kingdom has been evacuated and anyone who wasn't killed in the battle hasn't been reported missing. The Snows live on.”

Adora breathes a heavy sigh. “Right. This is war.” She looks Frosta in the eye with a cold, haunted stare. “I will make sure your people get their home back.”

Frosta, a little taken aback, nods thankfully.

Adora looks beyond the pair in the doorway. “Now let's go home.”

Chapter End Notes

This does it for Volume One! Sorry it took so long but I've been planning Volume Two a bit better and hopefully will have the first couple chapters out at some point soon!

End Notes

Thanks so much for reading! Thanks again to @spillthekatea for beta reading it for me and for working out the details in the fic!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!